Oh, These Aching Bones

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by IAmStoryteller

Summary

The cold weather rolls in and Izuku suffers unexpectedly, which leads to a series of events to make Class 1-A and a certain loudmouth childhood friend turned rival realize that despite Izuku's greatness as a hero, they have to look after him.

Notes

This is completely self-indulgent.

Izuku's 3rd POV, so there's use of Kacchan repeatedly throughout

See the end of the work for more notes

Leaves Are Changing But So Are We

One day it was a reasonable day and suddenly it hit Izuku that it was the middle of October and it was *cold*. It hit him because he woke up after a nice day of training in 20◦C/70◦F to a crisp 10◦C/50◦F to hands in throbbing pain. Izuku had a high pain tolerance, so he ignored it, thinking it just the cause of his bones breaking repeatedly at the beginning of the school year back in April and May and then again in July and August.

Thankfully as the day went on, the pain subsided to a dull ache that Izuku powered on through the day, even if it hurt write class notes and quirk notes in his notebook. To him, it wasn't a big deal and Izuku knew that no one noticed.

But then it happened again and again as the days got colder. The morning was the worst as was the late evening. Outside training now was not helping, because while when he really got moving and the adrenaline pumped through him, there was no pain. But once he settled back down, the pain in his hands doubled.

"Damn," muttered Izuku to himself, not one to curse a lot but allowed himself a 'damn' every once in a while, as he wandered to the kitchen to heat up a hot water bottle. It was the middle of the night and his room must have had some sort of heating/cooling problem or it was drafty as the dorms were built it quite a rush.

He kind of wished he could just stick his hands in warm water, but as he found out two days ago that just made it worse in the long run especially when the water cooled down. "I should probably go to Recovery Girl, but it is my fault that my hands are messed up. And I should mentioned the draftiness to Aizawa-sensei, but I don't want to be a bother…"

He found the kettle to heat up some water for his hot water bottle. This was just a temporary solution to a bigger problem. Izuku sighed as he sat on one of the stools. He gently rubbed his hands together for some friction, anything to ease the pain.

As he was trying not to fall asleep in the kitchen at midnight when he had to get up in a five hours for his morning run (which tripled sucked now with the cold weather), Izuku heard the tell-tale sound of someone walking into the common area.

"Nerd, you look like crap" said Kacchan, entering the kitchen. It was a standard greeting from him and he really didn't mean anything by it. He walked over to the fridge, in his sweatpants and slippers but no shirt because his body ran warm.

"Evening," mumbled Izuku. "Ran out of water in your room?" He knew that Kacchan kept a case or two of water in his room, because Kacchan had to keep hydrated especially when he wasn't moving thanks to his quirk.

"Yeah," Kacchan replied. Without missing a beat, "Why are you up so late?"

If anyone knew Izuku's behaviors, Kacchan knew him well. The explosive blond knew something was up with Izuku. Izuku had to admit that as the months passed, it had gotten

easier and easier to hold actual conversations with Kacchan that didn't sound forced or stilted. It helped that Kacchan knew Izuku's biggest secret and actually made efforts to help, in a roundabout sort of way, the Kacchan way of helping.

"Nothing, couldn't sleep," said Izuku. He already put a lot of burden on Kacchan with their shared secret. And besides, it really was Izuku's fault his hands hurt.

Kacchan moved closely and glared at Izuku. "Bullshit. You've been off for a couple of weeks, what the fuck is wrong?" Izuku frowned, but didn't look away from Kacchan's red-piercing stare. "Is it…" Kacchan looked around, scowling, "something with your quirk?"

Izuku sighed softly as the kettle whistled. "No, Kacchan. Nothing about my quirk. I'm fine." He got off the stool and padded over to the stove to fill his hot water bottle. He needed to make a quick escape.

Then, because he was a clumsy moron in the middle of the night, he dropped the hot water bottle on the floor, boiling water spurting everywhere because the pain shot through his hands as he tried to make them work right.

"Shit, Deku, you alright," said Kacchan, louder than appropriate for the nighttime, as Izuku's rival grabbed the nearby paper towels. Heat, even boiling water, didn't faze Kacchan much. Izuku just stood there, feeling like a helpless idiot, as Kacchan cleaned up Izuku's mess. "Nerd…?"

"Sorry, Kacchan," said Izuku, realizing that he was crying. He really ought to stop crying, he promised All Might he wasn't going to cry that much anymore.

Kacchan threw away the soaking wet towels and rounded on Izuku. Kacchan's expression was unreadable.

(And oh my, shirtless Kacchan was way too close).

It disturbed Izuku that Kacchan's expressions were becoming more and more varied to the point where once Izuku knew every little thing about Kacchan's facial expressions, now, some days, he couldn't even tell what was on Kacchan's mind. He supposed it was the price of growing up.

"Deku, tell me what's wrong *Right. Fucking. Now.*"

Izuku sniffled, and tried to wipe his eyes and face of tears with his hands but winced at the use of his hands. "Kacchan…"

Suddenly, Kacchan grabbed both of his hands.

The action stunned Izuku. (Holy moly, Kacchan was holding Izuku's hands. Kacchan's warm, warm hands were cradling Izuku's hurting hands with more gentleness than Izuku thought Kacchan was capable of…Izuku told himself not to freak out more).

"Your hands hurt," Kacchan stated.

Izuku just nodded, not trusting himself to speak.

“Use your words. You’re the one always complaining that I don’t use my words enough to communicate with you, so step the hell up and talk to me,” said Kacchan, surly. It was true. Communication and friendships were two-way streets.

Izuku croaked out, “My hands hurt. Since the colder weather started, I mean. It’s just the mornings and the evenings and while I sleep, and after outside training when I’m cooling down…”

Scowling, Kacchan said, “Just say all the time, dumbass. And no shit. You broke your hands and fingers to the point that you can’t make a proper fist anymore without straining it. What the fuck did you expect to happen? You’re going to Recovery Girl first thing tomorrow. Or I will tell All Might and he’ll make you go.”

“Bossy,” muttered Izuku. Kacchan growled and flicked Izuku on the forehead.

“Don’t be stubborn,” he told Izuku.

“Fine, I’ll go instead of doing my running,” said Izuku, realizing that this was a losing battle. Nodding, Kacchan seemed pleased smirking.

“In the meantime, I might have something that helps,” said Kacchan. He dragged Izuku along out of the kitchen and to the elevator. Izuku just followed without question. They went to the fourth floor, to Kacchan’s floor, to Kacchan’s room. The blond opened his door and looked at Izuku. “Wait out here.”

Izuku was not going to enter Kacchan’s room. He knew better. In a few moments, Kacchan came back out of his room, carrying a throw blanket. Izuku must have a confused look on his face because Kacchan said, “It’s a heated throw. The old man packed it just in case I needed it. Just…keep it.”

Izuku took the offered blanket. “Thank you, Kacchan. This was very thoughtful.” Izuku knew he was tired because it looked like Kacchan was blushing. But that couldn’t be, right? Kacchan didn’t get embarrassed.

“Well, just go to the fucking nurse tomorrow nerd and we’ll be even.”

“Okay.”

“Great. G’night.”

With that, Kacchan went back into his room and shut the door (and he didn’t even slam it!). Izuku grinned and went to the elevator to go back to his room and put his present to good use and finally getting some well-deserved rest.

Seasons Change

Chapter Summary

Katsuki doesn't care what Deku does.

(He's lying)

Chapter Notes

Since they're still in their first year, Katsuki's still deep in denial.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Katsuki grimaced along with the rest of the class stumbled into their loggings from the bitter cold of their winter mountain rescue training for a long midday lunch break (to eat, shower, or nap). Katsuki ran warm, but after three hours in snow and bitter cold, he was freezing just like the rest of them, including Todoroki who looked like he was getting a cold. The warm air of the heated building was a relief for everyone.

He took off his winter boots and meant to trudge to his shared room with Kirishima, Sero and Kaminari (there were four boys to the room and thankfully, they weren't too bad to share a room with). Of course, there was a green jittery bug that caught Katsuki's attention. Deku looked like he was full of nervous energy, but in reality, Katsuki knew that Deku was just trying to keep warm and from his body, specifically his hands, to start acting up from the cold.

It didn't help that Deku did most of the heavy lifting thanks to his quirk during their morning rescue training, while Todoroki and Katsuki were on melting the snow slowly without causing more problems.

Snorting, he followed Kirishima to the stairs. Kirishima and Kaminari were chatting amicably while Sero looked like he just wanted his bed. Katsuki shouldn't be worrying about that annoying nerd. Deku took up far too much of his thoughts lately.

Katsuki reached the shared room with his friends—Sero plopped himself on his futon and passed out; while Kaminari grabbed his bathroom stuff and ran off to the bathroom to shower.

"You okay? You look madder than usual," Kirishima asked.

"M'fine," grunted Katsuki.

It wasn't Katsuki's fault that Deku was completely awful at taking care of himself.

And Katsuki really shouldn't care, except he kind of always cared and always had a sense about Deku since he knew the green haired boy so well. Katsuki promised that things would be different after their fight after the provisional licensing exams and after learning about Deku's chosen one status. Things were different.

It was the middle of January that they were nearing the end of their first year at UA. And Katsuki safely could say that things between him and Deku were better than before. They even managed to have conversations without breaking into a fight or Katsuki having a screaming rage fit.

He's got anger issues and he's been working on it.

"Uh, I think I'll just leave you to be emotionally constipated right now. Don't blow up the room," said Kirishima, not scared but more amused than anything, making a break for the exit. No one in this class was afraid of Katsuki—they mostly ignored him when he went into a rage and it was probably a big factor in him mellowing out.

He stored his hero uniform and dressed in casual clothes, but warm clothes. Sero had the right idea. A nap was a good idea.

But not really because he was hungry, so hopefully afternoon training was going to be something simpler than a mock avalanche mountain rescue. He definitely had to go to bed early tonight.

Katsuki left Sero napping and he heard Kirishima and Kaminari being loud and ridiculous in the communal bathing area. Some of the others boys were heading for baths, and most of them nodded at Katsuki in greeting. Deku was nowhere in sight.

He went down to the large dining room, where the hosts (retired pro-heroes who were letting UA used there inn as a training camp, since it was the off-season for tourists and vacationers) provided a big buffet for the students. Katsuki was glad that he didn't have to cook his own food, not that it would be a problem.

But he found Deku being coddled by the girls of their class and for some reason, lately, it had been setting Katsuki on edge. Since that night in October, Deku had gone to see Recovery Girl and gotten some methods of dealing with the pain.

Then, Deku went and asked Momo if she could help him make his room less drafty. Combined with Momo's Creation quirk and Todoroki's actual handyman skills, Deku's room was insulated from the draft of winter winds. And that started the other girls checking up on Deku.

Asui wasn't good in the winter either, so she gave Deku plenty of tips for staying warm. Uraraka was on Deku to be eating more regular meals (Deku was known to skip a real breakfast for one of those protein shakes). Hagakure, surprisingly, knew how to knit and made Deku a new set of handmade gloves every week. Mina and Jiroh gave Deku some tips to learn how to relax more with hobbies other than hero and quirk stuff.

It was good that the others fussed over Deku's well-being. Everyone loved Deku in this class. Hell, even in other class, Deku was well-loved.

Deku wasn't that lonely kid (because of Katsuki, his mind so unhelpfully supplied) that didn't have any friends. It was good for Deku. Really.

But still, Katsuki found himself worrying about Deku nonetheless. Deku was good at bottling things up inside—not really wanting to be a bother to anyone. An irritating trait that had been with Deku since they were in diapers.

He grabbed a plate and began piling some food on it, while grumbling greetings to Deku and the girls.

He sat in a chair nearby and began eating, and trying not to look into Deku's direction.

Katsuki failed miserably, because he noticed the way that Deku was wincing slightly as he fumbled around with his chopsticks to eat. Deku actually wasn't eating much at this point and unfortunately, the girls had went from fussing over Deku to talking about the some book they were all reading (did the girls have a goddamn book club?) so they didn't notice.

Grumbling under his breath that no one noticed, Katsuki tried to focus on eating and preparing for afternoon training. He didn't want to care.

However, when he finished eating, he stomped his way to the kitchen. He found some fruit and vegetables and went to work, after locating the blender in the kitchen. The hostess entered and asked if Katsuki needed any help and he told her no. But then reconsidered when he didn't have a container to use, so she showed him the various drinking containers for his use.

He managed to finish creating a fruit and vegetable smoothie just before Aizawa-sensei called them for afternoon training. Katsuki had to rush up to his room and change back into his costume and get to the meeting spot for afternoon training, which thankfully was going to be quirk conditioning training.

Lidded cup in hand, Katsuki walked over to Deku and shoved the cup into Deku's hands, without a word for his reasoning or what it was. And then, he promptly walked away to join Kirishima for training.

Chapter End Notes

We all agree that Deku is shit at taking care of himself right?

Everything Stays

Chapter Summary

Everyone notices that things have changed with Midoriya and Bakugou.

Chapter Notes

I decided to get an outsider POV, so I picked one of the quieter students, someone who doesn't get more screen time (he totally should, I love Class 1-A), but also someone that was there when Kacchan was taken.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shoji really wished that he gotten assigned to another room, because it was just his luck that he got stuck with the three loudest sleepers in the class. They were also super messy and so much clutter was really throwing him off. Not being able to sleep on a training camp like this was not a good thing because as an aspiring hero, he needed as much as sleep as he could manage.

He softly went down the stairs to get to the kitchen for some water. He was the tallest in the class but that didn't mean that he wasn't a quiet person. When he reached the ground floor, the fire was still on in the fireplace (something about ambience, he was told). He saw two familiar messy heads of hair.

Bakugou and Midoriya.

Shoji paused. For once, they weren't arguing or competing. Bakugou wasn't being his loud self, speaking softly to Midoriya. And Midoriya wasn't talking a mile a minute. They were sitting in a companionable silence, side-by-side. Shoji didn't miss the way they were leaned towards each other. Shoji noticed that sometimes they were wrapped up in their own little world without realizing it.

Softly, he backtracked. He knew that the girls were having a big sleepover in their room and probably had some snacks and drinks. He just ask them for some water. As he walked back up the stairs, he thought it was a very good thing to see Bakugou and Midoriya getting along so well these days. It was surely different than at the beginning of the school year.

Shoji wasn't particularly close to either of them, but he was friendly with Midoriya and respected him. Midoriya was just so full of life and passion for being a hero. Shoji couldn't help but admire Midoriya.

Bakugou was quite more difficult to get used to, but once you realized that the loud, explosiveness was a shield for Bakugou's insecurities and inferiority complex, he wasn't so bad. Shoji had felt bad back in the summer when Bakugou had been taken by the League of Villains, he was kind of alright so long as you didn't piss him off too much. And while he knew that it wasn't in him to go after the pros gotten involved, he still didn't say anything to the teachers about the unauthorized mission. Eventually though, Shoji had taken the time to apologize to Bakugou when they had to do an assignment together, but Bakugou didn't seem particular hurt that only five of his classmates wanted to rescue him. However, Bakugou did take the apology with a "Don't worry about it. I get it."

Midoriya and Bakugou together, on the other hand, was an utterly baffling thing. He wasn't the only one in the class that were fascinated by their ever-changing dynamic.

Still, the night that Bakugou was taken, Shoji remembered he, Tokoyami, Todoroki, Uraraka and Asui watched the realization that Bakugou was gone set in on Midoriya. Shoji remembered the helplessness of hearing Midoriya's breakdown, because what do you say to someone that sounded like his heart had just been ripped out? The others didn't do anything because there was nothing they could do.

Logically, he knew that Midoriya would have been upset if it had been anyone else as well, but also that because it was *Bakugou*, it was different. With Midoriya's *Kacchan*, it was always different.

"Shoji, have you seen Midoriya," asked Todoroki, exiting the shared room of Iida, Midoriya, Todoroki and Tokoyami. Todoroki looked vaguely concerned.

Shoji replied, "He's downstairs. With Bakugou."

"Ah," said Todoroki, sighing softly. The worry was gone at the news. "Good."

Shoji sighed. "Yeah, they've been getting along a lot better lately."

"It's hard to help Midoriya when he's so good at hiding what's wrong," said Todoroki. "Iida and I miss things all the time."

"Bakugou doesn't miss a lot when it comes to Midoriya, that is true," said Shoji, knowing where Todoroki was going with it. Todoroki wasn't the only one frustrated that even after the months of being a class, after fighting alongside one another, Midoriya still opted to not depend on them. What were friends for if not but to help when it was needed? "As Ashido would say, the combined efforts of everyone in this class will mother-hen Midoriya into being safe and healthy."

Todoroki nodded. "So, why are you up?"

"Needed water."

Todoroki appraised Shoji and understood that he didn't wanted interrupt *whatever that was* downstairs. "I'll get you a water bottle from our stash, then."

Chapter End Notes

I leave this little story here.

Hope you enjoyed it.

Things Are Different Now, but Still Sort of the Same

Chapter Summary

> Shouto sits in the hospital alongside Bakugou and Kirishima, worrying over Midoriya...again

Chapter Notes

> HEAVY ANGST!! OR at least, heavy for my writing. If angst is not your thing, you can skip this.
>
> I've decided to continue this story for a few more chapters, with similar them about Bakugou and Class 1-A worrying over Midoriya and Midoriya needing to be broken of a bunch of bad habits.
>
> I updated the tags as necessary.
>
> This chapter is in Shouto's 3rd POV.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Shouto was good at many things. But as he sat in blood-stained (not his blood) clothes in a hustling, bustling emergency room waiting for news alongside a near-in-tears Kirishima, a very exhausted Aizawa-sensei, and a far-too-quiet Bakugou, the one thing he knew he was horrible at was comforting people.

What did you say to someone that almost watched a friend seemingly die? And not just any friend, Midoriya. Shouto's stoic face doesn't betray how he's feeling, but his stomach is in knots and he felt sick.

Their 1st Year Finals went horrible wrong. Class 1-A, soon-to-be 2-A, was no stranger to their training exercises and tests turning into a battle of survival against villains who either want to kill them all or kidnap one of them for some reason or another. Shouto wasn't surprised to find that despite the extra security of pros and police at the USJ, the villains came for them. It wasn't even the League of Villains this time, which was the most irritating part about it.

End of the year finals were three parts—Part 1 was the academic tests, Part 2 was mock villain battles at Ground Beta and Part 3 was mock rescue operations at the USJ.

It was foolish to think that they would get to Part 3 of their final exams without incident. Shouto had been teamed with Midoriya, Kirishima, and Bakugou in their mock rescue mission (unusual as they were all powerhouses, but sometimes the team-ups had more powerhouses available than people had more suited quirks to rescue) when the hired people they were rescuing (from the same company that hired the fake victims at their provisional license exams) had turned out to be an upcoming villain team under of the banner of Stain, calling themselves the Stainists.

Things got messy quickly especially when they found out where the real hired fake-victims were tied up and gagged on the USJ grounds.

Shouto wasn't sure what he was supposed to do, other than have nightmares for the foreseeable future of one of his best friends dying in front of him. No big deal right?

Still, he was the one that the most calm at this point. His teacher had a great frown on his face and looked like death-warmed over at the worry over Midoriya. Aizawa was the doctor's go-to-person at the moment. Unfortunately, Midoriya's mother had been out of town visiting her father and wouldn't be able to get back until early tomorrow morning so they were waiting for Midoriya's godmother, who had been Midoriya's other emergency contact. In the meantime, the doctors and surgeons were helping Midoriya the best they could to Shouto's knowledge.

Aizawa spoke, taking his phone out and texting someone. "Todoroki, I'm contacting Present Mic to pick you three up, since you're all unhurt. You will go back to the dorms, alright? Shower, eat, rest."

It was Kirishima on his feet even before Todoroki opened his mouth to protest. "I'm not leaving, sensei. There's no way that I can leave before I find out if Midoriya's going to be alright."

"Forgive me, sensei, I agree with Kirishima," said Todoroki, evenly as possible.

Aizawa sighed. Shouto knew that sigh. It was the sigh of a man thoroughly done. "There's nothing more you can do here, but worry yourselves and Midoriya wouldn't want that for you. The doctors told me that it was more blood than injury and it's not fatal, so he'll be fine. You two, Todoroki, Kirishima, are especially a mess. You need rest since you'll most likely be interviewed by the police tomorrow about the incident."

Shouto knew that Midoriya was a fighter…that he'll be alright (because he couldn't think of the alternative). It wasn't the first time that he or Kirishima or Aizawa sat in a hospital waiting for Midoriya and it wouldn't be the last. Shouto traded looks with Kirishima, as Aizawa's focus zeroed in on the completely silent Bakugou who hadn't spoken a word since arriving at the hospital. Then, Shouto understood where their teacher was coming from and Kirishima wiped his face of tears, smudging some dirt across his face.

"Alright, sensei," said Kirishima, still looking miserable, but he had a determined glint in his eyes.

Shouto nodded, in agreement. "Bakugou, we're going back to the dorms."

There was no response.

Kirishima shot Shouto a look of caution. Shouto knew that he wasn't Bakugou's favorite person so he let Kirishima, who was Bakugou's best friend at the point, handle the normally volatile boy.

"Bakugou, buddy, look at me," said Kirishima, trying to be calm and steady.

Shouto was concerned because he never seen such a blank look on Bakugou's normal expressive face.

Kirishima reached over and touched Bakugou's shoulder. The blond visibly flinched, but Kirishima had his attention.

"We're gonna go back to the dorms," said Kirishima, holding steady eye contact with Bakugou like he was a skittish animal.

Finally after far too long, Bakugou spoke, tone completely void of emotion. "Try to move my ass from this spot, any of you, I fucking dare you."

Kirishima flinched back. Shouto moved to stand next to the spiky red-head, just in case Bakugou got explode-y. "Bakugou…we should go and stay out of the adults' way." Of course, Todoroki wanted to stay but he knew that the others would want updates on Midoriya's status.

Bakugou didn't respond.

Thankfully, someone burst into the waiting room. "Where's Izuku?!" To Shouto's shock and Kirishima's shock, it was an adult female version of Bakugou marching over to them. Bakugou's mother was Midoriya's godmother?! "You! You're that teacher from the summer. What the fuck happened?"

Before Aizawa could even answer, the elder Bakugou rounded on her son and grabbing him into a hug. She was practically shielding her son from everything and everyone, despite her son being nearly as big as her. Shouto had a moment of envy shoot through him at the protectiveness of Bakugou's mother over him. "This isn't your blood, baby. Are you alright?" Bakugou muttered a response that only his mother could interpret.

"These three are unhurt," interrupted Aizawa, "Bakugou-san, there's some papers to fill out for Midoriya."

"Fine, but call me Mitsuki-san, at least," said Mitsuki, nodding. "I assume that you're sending them back to the dorms?" Aizawa nodded. Ruffling his son's hair, she ordered in no uncertain terms him. "Katsuki, you go with your friends. I'll look after Izuku until Inko gets here."

To Shouto's surprise, Bakugou just nodded in agreement. Shouto's heart couldn't take any more surprises, but today was a day for them. Bakugou Mitsuki sat Bakugou back down on

the chair and rounded on Shouto and Kirishima. “Are you two alright? Do you want me to call your parents for you?”

“It’s not our blood, ma’am,” said Kirishima, wincing.

Shouto merely shrugged. “We’re fine.”

Mitsuki appraised them with a similar look that Bakugou got when he was analyzing a situation. She moved closer to them and nodded. Whispering, she said, “Todoroki-kun, Kirishima-kun, look after my son alright? I know I can depend on you.”

Shouto felt a little stunned. Either Bakugou’s mother watched hero-in-training stuff religiously, or Bakugou actually talked about both Shouto and Kirishima to his mother. Kirishima looked wide-eyed and nodded, emphatically.

Ten minutes later, the three sixteen year old boys were piled in the back of an U.A. car with Present Mic in the driver’s seat. Bakugou sat between Shouto and Kirishima.

Shouto watched Bakugou out of the corner of his eye. Part of him didn’t know why Midoriya’s latest injury was bothering Bakugou so much more than all the other times. But the other part of Shouto knew.

Bakugou and Midoriya had been getting better slowly from their big fight in the summer. Bakugou pretended that he didn’t care for anything about Midoriya but Shouto knew that wasn’t the case. Everyone in the class knew that wasn’t the case.

Bakugou did watch the battle against Shigaraki and the League of Villains at the USJ and Shouto’s own battle against Midoriya at the Sports Festival. Bakugou even battled alongside Midoriya during last semester’s finals against All Might. At the time of all three, Bakugou was still angry with himself and Midoriya.

Of course, Bakugou didn’t see Midoriya fight Stain (like Todoroki and Iida did). Or Muscular (like young Kouta did). Or Overhaul (like Togata-senpai and young Eri). Bakugou only ever saw the after of those fights.

Things were different now.

(But maybe things weren’t *that* different. Shouto remembered the way that Bakugou jumped in front of Midoriya at the USJ. He also remembered the way that Bakugou faced down All Might so Midoriya could escape through the gate and pass their test. Shouto remembered the utter worry in Bakugou’s voice at the time of his kidnapping, with a “Don’t come, Deku.”)

Things were different when Bakugou cared enough to pay attention to the rest of the class trying to take care of Midoriya (and doing so mostly badly, Shouto had to admit). Bakugou cared enough to make Midoriya breakfast and bark at him to visit the nurse when Midoriya’s old injuries acted up.

And as he watched Kirishima place his hand over one of Bakugou’s hands in some sort of support, Shouto knew that it was only inevitable that Bakugou would witness Midoriya’s

self-destructive selflessness again. He knew that Bakugou was coming to terms with caring openly for his childhood friend again.

“He’s going to be fine,” said Shouto, glancing over at Bakugou’s face. “Midoriya will only come back stronger from this, you know.” And then, Shouto decided to do something impulsive. He placed his ice-side hand over Bakugou’s other hand, just like Kirishima.

“I hate him,” growled Bakugou, obviously lying about hating Midoriya and obviously trying not to cry, but failing. Shouto was surprised yet again to find Bakugou letting Shouto, of all people, hold his hand. “He’s a fucking impulsive, reckless, idiot and ***I hate him.*** He’s got a *fucking death wish* and it’s all ***my fault*** for making him think that’s he’s been useless all these years. No shitting thought of self-preservation in that smart but so fuckin’ stupid brain of his.”

Shouto pretended he didn’t see Bakugou breaking down into tears and heaving sobs.

“Maybe,” stated Shouto, not denying anything that Bakugou just said about Midoriya’s lack of caring about himself, but then said, “As his friends, we must make sure that Midoriya knows that he’s valued and loved and needed so he doesn’t think that his life isn’t worth anything. Because his life is worth everything.”

Kirishima half-smiled. “That is, in fact, our job. Right, Baku-bro?”

After a moment of breathing in and out slowly, Bakugou said, slowly “That might take the rest of our god-damn lives.” Bakugou didn’t seem too broken up about that fact.

Shouto looked out the window and smiled.

Chapter End Notes

Let me know what you think.

(It's kind of my headcanon since Izuku's dad's not really around that Inko needed someone to be a backup emergency contact, so...Mitsuki is designated) (I don't know about anywhere else, but most schools require at least three other emergency contacts in addition to parents)

All We've Got is Each Other.

Chapter Summary

Mitsuki sits and waits.

Chapter Notes

Izuku's kind of dopey in this chapter because he's just out of surgery and on medicine.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Bakugou Mitsuki sat in the chair right beside Izuku's hospital bed, where he was sleeping thanks to the anesthesia from the emergency surgery and the morphine drip for the pain. She sighed. When she got the call from the teacher Aizawa, Mitsuki thought it was about Katsuki and she almost panicked, but when it was not Katsuki but Izuku, Mitsuki's heart nearly stopped.

She had known that Inko was out of town visiting her old bastard of a father as Inko was a dutiful daughter, but Izuku had been doing so well lately. He had no major injuries since his internship with the Nighteye Agency and even that wasn't as bad as his injuries from that awful training camp where Mitsuki's only child got kidnapped by villains.

(On a side note, UA was so lucky that Masaru calmed Mitsuki down enough to *not* storm the school, demand answer or go look for Katsuki herself).

Inko was on the train at the moment on the way home and her frantic texts weren't helping Mitsuki's mood. Mitsuki hated to be worried; it made her angry especially when there wasn't anything that she could do fix things.

"My head feels funny, Auntie Mitchan," mumbled Izuku, waking up. He was obviously groggy and slurring his words. Izuku hadn't called her that nickname since he was about five. She doesn't think they've talked in a long time either. There was just so many factor in that fact and Mitsuki just had another thing in her long line of mistakes to be disappointed in herself concerning Izuku, Katsuki and Inko. "Are Kacchan, Todo-kun, and Kiri-kun okay?"

Mitsuki ruffled Izuku's hair gently and smiled. Like mother, like son, more concerned about someone else even when they were the ones laid up in bed. "They're all fine, but you gave them quite a scare. Do you remember what happened?"

“Mhmm-hmm,” hummed Izuku. “We were doing the test for the finals. And…and, me and Kacchan were fighting the bad guys and Kiri-kun and Todo-kun were moving all the bystanders to safety. We were doing so well, but then one of ‘em had swords for hands! It was crazy, Auntie Mitchan.”

Mitsuki brushed through Izuku’s already messy and very dirty hair with her fingers like she was used to do for Katsuki when he didn’t feel well. “Well, congratulations, Izuku, on managing not to break any of your bones with your quirk again, but managing to gain a scar across your chest like a badass anime swordsman.”

Izuku giggled, tiredly.

Mitsuki grinned. He really was out of it. Thankfully, due to the many healing quirks, Izuku wouldn’t be laid up for a couple of months to heal, but merely a couple of weeks. He still had stitches and staples for the time being. He was just very lucky that the swords didn’t cut any deeper, otherwise he would have been dead.

Mitsuki was never going to tell Inko that fact.

“You should rest. Mama Inko is almost here, alright,” said Mitsuki, softly.

“Ok,” said Izuku, shutting his eyes like he did when he was a kid that slept over her house and she told him and Katsuki to go to sleep. Mumbling one last thing before passing out, Izuku said, clearer than before, “I’m glad that you and Mom are talking again, Auntie. She really missed you.”

Sighing to herself, she pulled out her phone and texted Inko that Izuku woke up and he was doing fine and not to cry on the train in public like a weirdo. She also sent a text to Masaru and Katsuki that Izuku was doing well and not to worry so much.

Mitsuki was really glad that she made amends with her dearest friend, too. Mitsuki was not too proud to admit that she missed the Midoriya mother and son in her life. Things were a little brighter with them in her and her family’s life. She was glad to be there for Inko and Izuku when they needed someone in their corner. Mitsuki, and by extension, Katsuki, had a lot to make up for in her opinion.

“Ma’am, there’s more paperwork,” said one of the nurses, entering the room, snapping Mitsuki out of her thoughts.

“Yeah, yeah.” She couldn’t wait for Inko to get here. She hated paperwork, but for Izuku, she would handle the dreaded things.

Chapter End Notes

Next time: There's an intervention for Izuku! Sort of...

I also hate paperwork. I hate being an adult sometimes.

Little Talks

Chapter Summary

Izuku deals with the aftermath of this latest injury.

Chapter Notes

I really hope you like this chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It may have been night outside and very quiet in the hospital, save for the night shift nurses making their rounds, but Izuku just couldn't sleep anymore. He hated being in hospitals, even though he tended to spend more time in them than he would have liked. His mom arrived a couple of hours after Aunt Mitsuki came to the hospital, so when Izuku woke up, for real, this time, his mom and Aunt Mitsuki were talking in the serious adult tones.

Izuku had tried to convince his mother that he didn't need her to stay in the room with him, but his mom put her foot down and he knew better than to her argue with her when she got that look on her face. Aunt Mitsuki had been laughing about it when she left once Izuku's mother was settled. She had to get back to the office and pick up Uncle Masaru. She promised to come visit the next day to help get him back to U.A. since Izuku was being released tomorrow sometime.

His mother was given a small cot to use and she slept fitfully.

Sighing, he grabbed his mother's phone from the table, unplugging it from the charger, since his own phone had been with his school uniform in the lockers at the USJ. Izuku knew that he should be resting, but after the major drugs were flushed from his system, he was more wide awake than anything.

His mom's password was his birthday, and all he intended was to play some video game to pass the time.

What he didn't expect to see was a new incoming text. Izuku knew it was an invasion of privacy. His mom didn't have a lot of friends. Aside from the Bakugou couple, and a couple of coworkers from the library, and the doctor in charge of his maternal grandfather, his mom mostly kept to herself. She also had Grandpa's number, but he didn't text.

Izuku frowned immediately at the name he saw.

His mom was talking to his dad again. Izuku thought to himself, that maybe she never stopped? He and his mom did not talk about why his father was never home. They never talked about why she never just divorced him. (He suspected that it was due to his dad's really good job that providing Izuku and his mom with really good health insurance and the fact that his dad's job was also paying for Izuku's tuition at U.A. U.A. was super expensive, after all.)

Izuku didn't know how to feel about the name Hisashi still being in his mom's phone. Granted, his father wasn't a bad guy by any stretch of the imagination. The few memories of spending time with his dad were happy. And any time he did talk to his dad, his dad was always properly interested in Izuku and his interests and gave him words of encouragement.

It just was that maybe if he was lucky, his dad called him on Izuku's birthday. The last time, he's seen his dad in person, Izuku was six.

Curiosity got the better of Izuku and he scrolled all the way to the top of the texts between his parents. It was a new conversation, so maybe Izuku was jumping the gun with his mom and dad talking a lot again.

_~_~_~_~_

I: Just thought you ought to know that Izuku's hurt again and in the hospital. I'm on my way there since I was visiting my father, but according to Mitsuki, Izuku's in surgery

H: What? What happened? Is it bad like what I saw on the TV for the Sports Festival? Or worse like after that summer training camp where the Bakugou kid got nabbed? Do you need me to come to Japan?

I: Villains infiltrated the 3rd part of their final exams for this year. Mitsuki said that the doctor says that it was a sword cut but not deep, but a lot of blood loss. We don't need you to come Japan, Hisashi.

H: Right, right, okay.

H: Inko, I think we need to talk about this whole Izuku going to U.A. thing…

I: We don't.

H: Be reasonable. First fifteen years of his life, no problem. Moment that he got this late blooming quirk, serious hospital visits 3 times already in a year!

I: And we talked about this when you agreed to take that post overseas. All major Izuku related decisions are my call.

I: While I am worried about Izuku, I'm starting to come to terms with the life he's choosing to follow. He's going to get hurt, all heroes get hurt, it's normal. His teachers, especially All Might, see something special in Izuku. He's already a hero; he just needs to learn to be a better one that does get hurt every few months.

I: Shit happens, Hisashi. I can't force Izuku into being something he's not. And he's not someone who'll just sit back and do nothing.

H: I just don't want him to die recklessly, Inko! He's my son too, you know! I love him just as much as you do.

I: Well, maybe you should call him more. Anyway, I've got to go, the train arrived at the station. I'll update you if anything changes. Bye.

_~_~_~_~

Izuku looked over at his mother. He felt some tears in his eyes. She really was the best. And he knew that she had a hard time, especially after Kacchan getting kidnapped thing, and she almost pulled him out of U.A. She really does believe in him. But it was weird to know that his dad actually knew what was going on in Izuku's life. Izuku's been apart from his dad for so long that he forgot that his dad really did love him in his own way.

Then his mother's phone vibrated (because she always forgot to put the ringtone back on after work) with a notification of a call.

It was his dad.

His dad was calling.

Izuku, in the darkness of the hospital room, nearly panicked. Thanking the good fortune that the pain meds were relieving some of the joint pain in his hands, Izuku made the bold decision to answer the phone.

"Inko? Sorry to call so late. How's Izuku?"

Hearing the familiar, yet not familiar voice, Izuku teared up again. "I'm fine, Dad."

"Izu? You should be resting! Ugh, but hospitals, right? How're you feeling?"

"Little sore. Just some stitches and staples. I'll be going back to the dorms tomorrow," Izuku responded. He wanted to see how his dad reacted to the fact that Izuku was returning to U.A. after this event.

"Well, at least, Recovery Girl is the school doctor. Just make sure you listen to the doctor's orders. I know that once you start your second year the Sports Festival comes up, so you want to be ready to show everyone how much you improved. Do your best! But remember that I worry about you even if I'm not around as much as I should be. Just be careful from now on, alright, Izu?"

"Yeah, I'll take better care of myself. Thanks for checking up on me, Dad," replied Izuku.

"You should get to bed. I love you and miss you. Good night."

"Miss you too, Dad. Night."

_~_~_~_~_~

Izuku didn't tell his mom about the late night phone call with his dad but she probably knew because of the phone's logs. Thankfully, the arrival of Aunt Mitsuki and Uncle Masaru saved Izuku from any such questions as the three adults dealt with the doctors and the staff to get Izuku out of the hospital.

Once back at school, he had to find out how the finals went for him and if he needed to catch up on another. It was true that it was the end of the semester and the end of their 1st year, but there was only a brief reprieve before 2nd year started. Izuku knew that he had to be better and be ready for the 2nd Year Sports Festival. He hated to fall behind, since everyone else had an eleven year head start.

He was also going to have to apologize for worrying everyone, especially Aizawa-sensei, Kirishima, Todoroki and Kacchan.

Thanks to Aunt Mitsuki's big personality, the staff moved quicker to get them all out of the hospital and out of the way. Uncle Masaru drove them all to the gates of U.A. after ferrying Izuku out of the hospital. He even let them use the wheelchair to escort him out, if it got him out faster.

When they arrived, Aizawa-sensei and All Might were waiting at the gate. His mom must have sent word ahead of his arrival, since Izuku didn't have his school id that opened the gates.

"Make sure you call me every day in the morning and in the evening," said his mother, worry laced in her voice. She hugged him tightly. Izuku nodded and gave her a hug right back. "Let someone know if there's any problems, Izuku. I'm serious."

"Right," said Izuku, smiling. "Thanks for everything, Auntie, Uncle."

"You're so cute, Izuku! Nothing like my grumpy son. Say hi to him from us," said Mitsuki, giving him a soft hug too. Uncle Masaru just smiled warmly at Izuku. Uncle Masaru was a kindred spirit to Izuku and Kacchan's dad was the main male figure in Izuku's life other than All Might (and oh, right, Izuku's dad).

Once they headed out, Izuku was lead back into the school grounds by his teachers.

"Glad to see you in one piece, Midoriya," said Aizawa-sensei. "Everyone's waiting for you at the dorms." With that, Aizawa-sensei made a sharp right and left Izuku with All Might before Izuku got anything out of his mouth. Aizawa-sensei was good people.

All Might was quiet as Izuku walked alongside his mentor. "Sorry to worry you again."

"Nonsense. It was actually something that you couldn't help and this time it wasn't because of your quirk," said All Might, simply. "I'm always going to worry about you, my boy. You just keep growing and getting better. It's all I can ask of you."

"Thank you, sir."

“Your friends, on the other hand, have quite the bone to pick with you.”

_~_~_~_~_~

After his little walk with All Might, Izuku wished he was given a little bit more warning than some of them being annoyed with Izuku. He walked into the dorms common room area to find the entire class except Kacchan there.

Immediately, he was set upon by Uraraka, crying, and Kirishima, also crying. They hugged him, but gently (not bear hugs like they normally give to him) because of his wounds.

“WAHH! Deku-kun, you scared us so much.”

“Midoriya, buddy, you’re gonna give me gray hair,” said Kirishima, crying manly tears of worry.

Iida thankfully intercepted and said, “Calm down, you two. We have to do this intervention in an orderly manner befitting of Midoriya’s friends.”

“Do we really have to call it an intervention,” asked Izuku, out loud, wondering what was up with all his friends in the class. “What’s all this, guys?” He wasn’t answered as Uraraka and Iida dragged Izuku over to the dining room table that was covered in food. Izuku sat down and waited for someone to tell him what was going on with them.

“Uhmm, we have something that we want to tell you,” said Momo, sitting next to Izuku in the chair next to his. She looked a little nervous. She looked at the surrounding crowd of the rest of Class 1-A (where was Kacchan?). “Why do I have to be the one to do this?”

“Because, you’re one of the reasonable ones in this class,” responded everyone, but Izuku.

Momo take a deep breath. Izuku stared at her, baffled. Why was she so nervous? Did he fail the exams?

“We love you, Midoriya.”

Wait, hold up…Izuku’s mind blanked for a minute.

“Wha…?” Izuku face flushed bright red at the declaration. His eyes scanned the room and only saw earnest faces of his friends.

“Uh-oh, guys, I think we broke him,” startled Kirishima.

“Holy gumdrops, he’s crying!”

“Kaminari, just curse like a normal person, oh my God!”

Izuku listened to them all panic about making crossing some sort of boundary or about breaking Izuku’s brain. He knew he was crying. He was a crier, so sue him (please don’t). But the sentiment was mutual, so Izuku blurted out, voice choked with tears. “I love you guys, too!”

Then, there was mutual crying and cheers and more declarations of love amongst everyone and then Todoroki said, “So, depend on us more, Midoriya. We’re here for you.”

Izuku just cried some more.

(Still, where was Kacchan?)

_~_~_~_~_~

Once again, sleep eluded Izuku. He turned on his lights.

His friends were the best. He didn’t know they cared about him so much. Izuku never had many people telling him that he was loved—his mom told him all the time and that was about it. It was nice to be loved, he thought. This class became like his family in the time that they spent together, training and fighting.

It was about two in the morning and while he slept for a while, he woke up not really tired. He hated nights like this, but he didn’t have any homework and he was supposed to be resting. Tomorrow the others got to go to special training (on campus, of course), but Izuku couldn’t go, so he would do some meditating with All Might.

He picked up one of his books on quirks and decided to read until he was sleepy again.

Once he was engrossed in his book, he almost missed the soft knocking at the door of his dorm room. Izuku blinked and carefully got out of bed (he had to be wary of how he moved thanks to the stitches and staples, thank goodness for healing quirks that sped up the healing process) to answer the door.

Kacchan stared back at him when Izuku opened the door.

He was dressed in sweats and a t-shirt and he didn’t have a scowl on his face for once. In fact, this side of Kacchan, Izuku hadn’t seen in a very long time. Moving to the side, Izuku wordlessly invited Kacchan into his room.

As Izuku shut the door behind them, Izuku was reminded of the times when they were just little kids and got into petty fights and Kacchan came to apologize when he was being mean and angry.

“Kacchan?”

Kacchan didn’t respond, but instead took out a folded piece of paper.

“Are you ok, Kacchan?”

Kacchan’s scowl came back for a split second, but his face softened a just bit when he looked at Izuku. “Just. Let me talk for once, alright nerd?”

Izuku didn’t know what was happening. He was in new territory with Kacchan right now. It was kind of thrilling, so he shut his mouth to listen to whatever Kacchan had to say to him.

His childhood friend turned rival unfolded the paper. Izuku noted that both sides of the paper were written upon, with a lot of cross-outs and scribblings.

“Uh, so, I’m not good at this stuff, you know, so Pinky told me to write it down,” said Kacchan, grumbly. There was a nervous energy about Kacchan. He wasn’t quite himself, Izuku hoped there was something he could do to help Kacchan. “So…” Kacchan stared hard at the paper and refused to meet Izuku’s gaze.

“Kacchan?”

Growling in frustration, Kacchan crumbled the paper and threw in aside and then he lunged towards Izuku. On instinct, Izuku braced himself for violent impact, but was thoroughly surprised when Kacchan hugged him.

Izuku died. This was heaven and he was dead.

Kacchan was hugging him.

Holy gumdrops, *Kacchan was hugging him, Izuku!*

They haven’t hugged since they were four!

It was a gentle hug, mindful of Izuku’s aching wounds and Izuku’s face was resting on Kacchan’s shoulder.

“I’m sorry,” said Kacchan, softly.

“Why’re sorry, Kacchan,” Izuku’s voice muffled.

“For **everything.** For being a jackass most of our lives. For pushing you down and calling you useless, when it was just me being a damn coward because you were always meant to be a hero. I’m sorry for making you feel like you’re never good enough. Sorry for not being a better friend when I should have protected you when you couldn’t do it yourself. I’m sorry because I wasn’t *fast enough* to catch that fucking sword guy; sorry I couldn’t get to that bystander when I should have,” growled Kacchan, frustrated and crying. “*God, there was so much blood, I thought you were fucking dead!”*

“Kacchan…” started Izuku, breaking apart from the hug, very reluctantly. Izuku had no idea that this was deep in Kacchan’s heart. Kacchan was crying. And he was so muted. That was the word, muted. Sternly, with no room for argument, “I’ve always known that you were sorry. You told me things were going to be different after our Ground Beta fight, yeah? It has been. Your actions speak louder than words, though I appreciate the words. And this,” continued Izuku, gesturing to his chest wound, “was not your fault. Not an ounce. We’re heroes and things are going to happen, alright? You have to trust me enough that I’ll be okay.”

Izuku was pulled into another hug. Kacchan was crying on Izuku’s shoulder.

“I’m gonna be better, Izuku. I promise. No more bullshit, alright,” said Kacchan, doing his frustrated crying thing. “And you are fucking going to stop trying to throw your life away at

random. You gotta promise me that."

Izuku soothingly ran his fingers through Kacchan's hair. "I promise that I'll do my best."

Kacchan jerked away suddenly. Deadly serious, red eyes narrowed, "I can't lose you. That promise isn't good enough."

Kacchan couldn't lose Izuku.

"Well, I can't lose you, either. If it's me or you, I'd rather—"

Izuku startled when Kacchan grabbed the back of Izuku's head and pushed their foreheads together so they were staring at each other, eye to eye.

They were close enough that Izuku almost wished to lean over and kiss Kacchan, but now was not the time. Izuku always loved the intensity of Kacchan's eyes. "You're worthy of living, Izuku. NO life is worth more than another's. Dead heroes can't save anyone, right? So promise *me."*

Izuku breathed hitched at the unnamed emotion in Kacchan's eyes. "Only if you help me."

"Every day, nerd. Promise, ***now."***

"I promise that I won't throw my life away, because I'm going to be a hero with Kacchan and all my friends here and dead heroes can't save anyone."

Chapter End Notes

My thoughts on Izuku's dad Hisashi:
I'm hoping that he's not a bad person. That being said, I think there's more going on with the Midoriya family.

I hope you all get where I was trying to go. Izuku's dad loves Izuku and he is, at best, an less-than-average dad, but not a bad father. He could stand to visit and talk to his son more, a lot more actually. Some parents are really good like Inko. Most are average, trying their best, and missing the mark sometimes.

But that's just my two cents.

Let me know what you think of this chapter.

What's in a Name?

Chapter Summary

Kirishima has some realizations.

And Eri makes an appearance.

Chapter Notes

This one is much more fluffy and less angst than the others.

The class started their second year.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Things fell into line for the newly-minted Class 2-A (with their disastrous finals exams, they were only graded on the first two parts completed). Shinsou Hitoshi joined their class as a Hero Course student and the mind-control quirk user found himself with a bunch more friends than he expected. They were placed once again under the tutelage of Aizawa as their homeroom teacher.

And the class fell into patterns taking care of each other, to raise each other up, especially everyone chipping in to watch out for Midoriya. Eijirou had the privilege of being one of the few that was allowed to hug Midoriya without the green-haired boy being too embarrassed. It was an honor.

Still, nothing was better than seeing Bakugou and Midoriya getting along without a hitch. They were more at ease with each other, especially Bakugou. Eijirou suspected that the incident made Bakugou realize how much Midoriya meant to him.

Eijirou had been beyond thrilled when the morning after Midoriya came home from the hospital, Bakugou made Midoriya breakfast before the rest of the class went off for special training. It was obvious that Midoriya got special treatment from Bakugou the most, but the rest of the class stepped up looking after Midoriya.

Eijirou was just glad that Midoriya was flourishing under the love and praise of this Class 2-A family. It seemed that Midoriya was taking his health and safety more seriously than before. Things were good.

And of course, the class was spurred on once Midoriya was cleared for training. Eijirou spent free evenings sparring with Bakugou and Midoriya. He went running in the mornings with Iida and Yao-momo. The others were similarly setting up training with each other to be better prepared for their internships.

Within three weeks of beginning their second year, the Sports Festival was upon them. Naturally, the new batch of first years did their Sports Festival first, so their Class got a chance to watch the up and comers.

“We’re gonna need to get you a new notebook at this rate,” said Eijirou, who was sitting next to Midoriya, Uraraka and Bakugou in one row with the rest of the Class spread out in the stands watching the first years. Midoriya was busy scribbling away, studying and analyzing the new students’ quirks and abilities. “Who do you think will win this year, Mido?”

Midoriya grinned at the question. “Well, I’d say that it’s a close call this year between Yamamoto Setsuna, who entered UA on the only recommendation this year, and Takahiro Daisuke, the kid who had the top scores in the entrance exams.” He kept on mumbling, talking about a mock match between their quirks and their current skill sets and Eijirou didn’t catch everything he was talking about when Midoriya mumbled up a storm, but Midoriya was just happy to be heard.

Uraraka and Kirishima just traded amused, fond looks. Bakugou rolled his eyes.

“Please, that chicken kid will take down the rich girl, because she’s hesitant to hit anyone,” said Bakugou, who was the only one that could follow Midoriya’s mumbling. Honestly, they were each other’s interpreter. Bakugou understood Midoriya’s nerdy mumblings was a way to let anxiety out and Midoriya understood that Bakugou’s harsh-sounding words were just a front.

“Geez, Kaachan, at least give them better nicknames if you aren’t going to remember their names,” said Midoriya, smiling at Bakugou.

Eijirou grinned as he heard the two childhood friends began bickering good-naturedly.

Uraraka whispered, “They’re like an old married couple sometimes.”

Eijirou had to giggle at that statement, because it was true.

“Deku! I missed you!”

All eyes turned to the familiar voice of Eri, the little girl, who came bounding up to them, with Aizawa close behind her. Eri was a welcome guest at the Class 2-A dorms when she wasn’t busy with school lessons herself. Eri’s favorite person was Midoriya Izuku and for good reason. Thank heavens, she had been away with Lemillion, Suneater, and Nejire-chan on a trip when Deku got injured, so she didn’t have to worry or cry.

Eri was Class 2-A’s unofficial little sister.

“Eri-san, how was your trip,” Midoriya immediately asked, rushing to meet her with outstretched arms for a hug. It was safe to say that Midoriya adored the little girl as he hugged her gently. Since Eri’s been at UA, she had to go through some therapy for the trauma that she experienced and it took some time to get used to everyone. Really the ones that she was most comfortable with were Midoriya, Lemillion and Aizawa-sensei, but Eijirou thought that he was getting through to her when she shot him and Uraraka hesitant, but soft smiles from her spot in Midoriya’s arms.

“It was fun. I ate a lot of good food and we got to go to an aquarium,” said Eri, with a big smile on her face just for Midoriya.

“Good, good. And with you here to cheer for us, we’ll all be extra Plus Ultra,” said Midoriya, brightly.

Eri looked pleased with the compliment. She launched into the tale about her trip.

Eijirou smiled and turned his attention to the 1st years currently duking it out when Uraraka nudged him hard. She didn’t know her own strength sometimes, but when he went to complain, she titled her head towards Bakugou.

Bakugou was watching Midoriya and Eri cutely babble together. Eijirou, in the year that he’s known Bakugou, had never seen him make such a look on his face.

Soft looks should have looked unusual on Bakugou’s face, but this one didn’t.

Eijirou looked away. Bakugou just looked so fond staring at Midoriya and Eijirou wondered how long Bakugou had been giving Midoriya such looks without anyone noticing. Did Bakugou even notice? Knowing his friend, Bakugou was probably oblivious to anything other than platonic feelings.

Oh, bro, thought Eijirou. Bakugou was so in love with Midoriya that the explosive teen didn’t even know himself. All Eijirou could ask was that they kept slowly repairing their friendship before anything else.

“Oh, here. This is for you,” said Eri, pulling out of her little bag a card. Midoriya thanked her and took the card. “I heard you got hurt again, saving someone.” Everyone shot Aizawa-sensei a dirty look, who just shrugged. One of their senpai must have accidentally let it slip. “I’m just so happy that you’re okay.”

Midoriya started tearing up. “Thanks, Eri-san, this is wonderful.” He opened the card and promptly burst into tears.

Eijirou was on his feet before Bakugou for once, who followed Eijirou, and reached Midoriya’s side to see the card state in crayon and marker “DEKU IS MY HERO” with a great attempted drawing of Deku in his hero gear, standing next to Eri’s attempted self-portrait.

Patting Midoriya on the back in a comforting manner, Eijirou grinned. “Don’t worry, Eri-san. These are tears of happiness.” Eri beamed and gave Midoriya another hug.

Bakugou stood on the other side of Midoriya and he just stared at the card. And Bakugou smirked. “Geez, nerd, why’re crying? Deku is the name of a hero, after all.”

Eijirou laughed. Yeah, Bakugou’s got it bad for Midoriya, alright. He just didn’t know it yet.

Chapter End Notes

I don't know if you noticed but Kirishima and Todoroki are two of my favorite MHA characters, other than Izuku, Katsuki and my girl Momo.

Let me know what you think. I'm hoping to have the last three chapters written today so I can release them all by Mon or Tues.

Listen

Chapter Summary

Spring arrives early and Izuku realizes something that could break everything.

Chapter Notes

WARNING: Izuku has a mild anxiety freak out near the end of the chapter. If it makes you uncomfortable, skip it.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Spring arrived early, or rather, the weather warmed to the point where Izuku's joints didn't scream with pain. Warm weather was good for him. Of course, Recovery Girl, his mom, All Might, Aizawa-sensei, Kacchan and everyone else in the class told him that just because he was feeling better that he shouldn't push himself to extremes. Kacchan had basically assigned himself to look out for Izuku. Izuku knew what his oldest friend was doing and he was grateful.

Especially grateful, because Izuku really felt that he was standing on equal ground with Kacchan, really being his friend. They weren't best friends like Izuku always hoped, because Kacchan's best friends were Kirishima, Ashido, Kaminari and Sero AND Izuku's best friends were Iida, Uraraka and Todoroki. But Izuku laid claim to Kacchan's oldest friend, his childhood friend and his rival and vice versa. It was great being friends again with Kacchan, even though Izuku never thought of them as less than friends. Rather it was nice that Kacchan saw them as friends again.

It was also amazing that he found so many people to fit in his makeshift family. It had always been his mother and himself, and even though his dad loved Izuku, he wasn't around much to make Izuku think of him as indispensable. He could live *without* his dad.

Izuku wouldn't know what to do without his *nakama* in Class 1-A. Or the encouraging teachers at U.A. or his senpai.

All these reasons and more was why he was up before sunrise going on an early morning, pre-class run around campus with Kacchan. Since it was early spring there was a chill in the air, but it wasn't the bitter cold that hurt. The ground was wet and soft from a late night rain and it just smelled like spring.

“Twice around campus and then it’s our turn to make breakfast for everyone,” said Kacchan. They were doing their pre-running stretches so they didn’t pull a muscle or hurt themselves. Everyone in class was becoming better and better at cooking and other household tasks like laundry, generally becoming self-sufficient. Still, Kacchan and Izuku made the best breakfasts, while Momo and, surprisingly, Shinsou made the best dinners.

“Right,” said Izuku, grinning softly. There were no words to describe how much Izuku liked spending peaceful training time with Kacchan.

“First one back does the dishes,” said Kacchan, before sprinting off ahead of Izuku.

Izuku protested, “Kacchan! No fair!” He used just a few percent of One for All to propel himself forward to catch up to Kacchan. Of course, the competitive streak in Izuku caused him to run just little ways ahead of Kacchan, before stopping the use of his quirk. Technically, they both agreed not to use their quirks in their running, but every so often, they both did.

“Competitive little shit,” said Kacchan, catching up to Izuku easily and matching his running pace with him. Kacchan was teasing him like real friends did.

Izuku laughed. “Well, I’m not the only one.”

Kacchan chuckled. But then it was like Izuku was slapped as Izuku’s eyes locked with Kacchan’s. Kacchan was smiling. And Izuku’s mind short-circuited because Kacchan was *smiling at him.* A real smile, like when they were younger before everything got so messy between them; like there wasn’t years of misunderstandings, lies, pain, anger, hatred there scarred over with their newly mended friendship and rivalry.

Izuku loved Kacchan’s smile, which made him look younger and more carefree than his normal scowling or smirking face.

Promptly, at the realization, Izuku tripped over his own two feet and fell on his face with the newest understanding that he, Midoriya Izuku, *really totally liked probably even loved* Kacchan.

“Crap, Deku, what the fuck? Are you okay?” Kacchan kneeled down by Izuku and helped him up. Still holding on to Izuku’s arm, Kacchan frowned. “Your face is bright red. Are you getting a fever? Fuck, let’s go wake up the old lady…”

Izuku snapped out of it when Kacchan began pulling him along with a panicked squeak. “Ah, Kacchan, I’m okay. I…uh, just got overheated for a moment. I’m fine.”

Kacchan’s narrowed, clearly not believing Izuku. “Say something if you’re not feeling well, let’s go back to the dorms.”

Izuku just avoided looking at Kacchan on the way back. Because he couldn’t like Kacchan like that! They just became friends again. It was just a trick his mind was playing on him. They were just spending too much time together again and Izuku’s nostalgia and admiration was clearly clouding his judgement concerning Kacchan.

Izuku was just happy enough to be Kacchan's friend.

That was it.

_~_~_~_~_~

"You're a disaster today," said Ashido, bounding up to him as they waited their turn to do the morning training exercise. She grinned at him. Izuku always liked Ashido's confidence. "What happened?"

It was a blessing and curse that his friends were all so attentive to him now. It was great because he knew that each and every one of them loved him and would do anything for him. But it also kind of sucked that whenever Izuku had an off day, they wanted to help. He loved his friends. He really did.

"Nothing," said Izuku, feeling someone staring at his back. He turned to find Kacchan glaring at his back. Ever since morning, Izuku found that he was super embarrassed and couldn't string a proper sentence together to Kacchan. It was highly annoying to himself, so he could only imagine what Kacchan was thinking at the moment. And they were doing so good lately.

Ashido knowingly smiled as she looked at where Izuku was staring and then back at Izuku. "Ah, okay. Say no more." Then, surprisingly, she dropped the issue. Ashido never dropped anything when she found it to be interesting. She was always so gung-ho.

It was their turn to run into the fake burning and collapsing building to save the "victim" (Miss Midnight this time).

He would worry later if that meant that Ashido knew about Izuku's possible feelings for Kacchan. And if Ashido knew, who else might have be savvy enough to notice before Izuku knew himself?

"Come on, Mido!! Let's go be heroes!"

Later, Izuku would panic about his multiple existential crises, but now he had a job to do alongside Ashido.

_~_~_~_~_~_~

Izuku ate his lunch in silence as All Might gave him a look of concern. His mentor was sipping some tea in his office and Izuku couldn't stand his class' well-meaning looks of concern nor the confused and somewhat hurt looks that Kacchan was giving him. He grabbed his lunch from the cafeteria and rushed to find All Might and eat lunch with him. They did eat lunch together sometimes when they could get away with it.

"So, are you going to tell me why you're hiding out with this old man and not hanging out with your friends at lunch time, the only real time of day where you all have free time to just be teenagers," asked All Might, finally breaching the topic that Izuku knew he just wanted to know. "Come, Young Midoriya, you can tell me anything."

Izuku nervously laughed. “You’re not old, sir. And I don’t think this is a hero-related or quirk-related thing you can help me with, no offense.”

All Might sighed. “Is this a girl problem?”

Izuku’s face lit up like a Christmas tree. “What? No, sir! It took me months to get used to Uraraka-chan, Ashido, Yao-momo, Hagakure, Jirou, and Asui-Tsu without bursting into flames in embarrassment! It is most definitely not a girl problem!”

“Alright, alright, forgive me for the assumption” said All Might, chuckling, and holding up his hands in defense. Then in a more serious, “Is this a Young Bakugou situation then?”

Izuku dropped his chopsticks and he felt his face reddened even more. The words came tumbling out of his mouth before he could stop himself. “Wha? No, nope, nope, nope, I’m not having this conversation. I can’t do this, oh my God. What the hell? Does everyone suspect? God, what if Kacchan knows? *Oh my God,* ***what if Kacchan knows?*** This will mess everything up. Ashido was right. I’m a disaster, a barely functioning disaster. Ohh, I can’t have Kacchan ignore me again. I can’t imagine being without Kacchan again. It was so hard the first time. Ugh, this is such a mess. Stupid Izuku, good job for falling in love with Kacchan. Holy Shitake mushrooms, I’m actually ***in love*** with *Kacchan.* I think I’m going to pass out…”

Then Izuku felt a gentleness—All Might was hugging him and patting his head. “Easy there, Young Midoriya, easy. Everything is going be okay. Just breathe.”

Izuku breathed in and out, feeling safe in the arms of his mentor and his surrogate father figure (sorry biological dad out in the world). “All Might? What am I going to do?”

“First, you’re going to calm yourself before you start a panic attack,” said All Might, still hugging him. Izuku nodded. It took a few minutes before Izuku was calm enough, his heart beat slowed down and he didn’t feel like he was floundering anymore.

“Sir?”

“Now, let’s start at the beginning,” said All Might, clearing his throat. Admittedly, I don’t have much expertise in the matters of the heart, but I will do my best to give you advice.”

“It’s fine, sir, I can figure it…”

“Nonsense,” said All Might. “So you’ve realized that you have stronger feelings towards Young Bakugou and you’re worried that it will mess up your newly mended friendship and rivalry and you don’t know what to do with the knowledge that you love him, yes?”

Izuku just nodded, mutely. All Might was right.

“It stands to reason,” continued All Might, calmly, “that you’ve had these feelings for longer than you realized and that it will not change anything unless you want it to…But I think that if you merely communicate with Young Bakugou, it won’t be as bad as you imagine.”

Izuku buried his face in his hands and groaned. “Are you telling me to act like I always had around Kacchan because I’ve had these feelings for a long time? Or just tell him how I feel and make things more awkward than they are now?” Izuku knew that Kacchan wouldn’t possible return any semblance of feelings like Izuku felt towards him, but Kacchan wouldn’t go back to hating Izuku again. As long as Kacchan still remained his friend, it shouldn’t matter Izuku’s feelings.

“I’m sorry that I’m not much help, my boy.”

“It’s okay, All Might. This is a mess…”

His mentor sighed and Izuku also sighed.

Then, Izuku saw something on All Might’s desk.

“Sir, is that a teaching book about dealing with teenage emotions?”

“…No.”

Chapter End Notes

And now we're onto the drama.

Blinding

Chapter Summary

Ochako worries about Deku and Bakugou.

Chapter Notes

Since this story is vaguely canon compliant, I had to address Ochako's feelings for Deku. It's only fair to her, because her feelings are valid (and totally understandable).

Also, you can pry Protective Warrior Maiden Ochako from my cold dead hands.

Hope you enjoy the chapter.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Deku was acting weird all day. It was especially strange for him to just to run off at lunch to God-knows-where and then barely make it to the afternoon class on time. Ochako, from her place in the back of the classroom, watched Deku. He was flustered and very much staring at Bakugou's back.

As far as she knew, they weren't arguing. In fact, it was almost like Deku was being weird around Bakugou. They were fine yesterday when they actually went out to dinner after their internship patrols and brought back ice cream for everyone. Ochako knew they went running in the morning together before everyone else.

She was trying to pay attention to class, but she was far too worried about Deku and Bakugou. There was nothing more amazing than seeing them become friends again, or rather mend their relationship so that they were able to be better friends. While Present Mic was talking about some weird English verbs, a small note landed on her desk.

She immediately recognized the cheery yet messy handwriting of Mina. She quickly but discreetly opened it and read what Mina said.

"Mido realized that he has a big old, fat crush on Baku. Sorry, girl. ♥"

Ochako sighed ever so softly. She knew that the day would come when she would have to face the facts. Ochako turned her attention back to watching Deku mindlessly write notes while still staring at Bakugou's back.

Oh, well, she told herself. It's not like she didn't know it was coming. She wasn't in the hero course for shits and giggles. She had been mentally preparing herself since the training camp when she saw Deku's breakdown over losing Bakugou to the villains. It was honestly one of the most heart-wrenching moments in her life to hear the utter despair in Deku's voice and see him broken mentally and physically over the situation. But she really didn't understand it at the time.

It wasn't until the day after their fight after the provisional licensing exam that Ochako understood when she asked Deku if he and Bakugou made up. The light in Deku's eyes and the wobbly smile on his face was enough to make her really see for the first time how much Bakugou meant to Deku.

There was comfort in the fact that, reasonably, she knew that Deku saw her as his best friend and that in itself was amazing. She admired him and looked to him for guidance in being a hero. Deku was such a sweet guy. She was glad to have Deku in her life and she knew that he loved her, just as a friend.

As Present Mic loudly went on and on about English verbs and their uses, which she really should be studying because English was her worst subject but Momo would help her later, Ochako's eyes drifted to where Deku was looking at the steady form of Bakugou.

Bakugou seemingly was the biggest asshole that graced the campus at first glance who didn't use anyone's name and constantly butted heads with everyone because of his ego. But Ochako fought him head-to-head and earned the explosive boy's respect, which was not given out lightly. He was intensely passionate about winning, about being the best. He was so certain of himself and with good reason—he was insanely powerful, skilled, intelligent, and perceptive. He admired strength and persistence in others.

That reason alone was why it was so baffling that Bakugou seemed to hate Deku, because Deku was strong and never gave up. Granted, the two known each other their entire lives so there were things that the rest of the class didn't know about them and their ever-evolving complicated relationship. But quickly realized that Bakugou didn't hate Deku, never really hated him, he was baffled and frightened of Deku's strong heroic heart.

As time went on, especially after their second Ground Beta, Ochako watched the small subtle changes in Bakugou. He hung around with Kirishima, Kaminari, Sero and Mina, all the while complaining about it. He and Todoroki egged each other on with barbed comments that only seemed funny to them. Bakugou even took Ochako up on offers for spars.

The most notable change was that Bakugou took to watching out for Deku more. He was the one that alerted everyone to Deku's bad habits, not outright but it was obvious that he was trying to show everyone that Deku didn't want to rely on everyone when he really needed them to do so. He was the one who told them to make sure Deku ate all his meals. If Bakugou wasn't the one dragging Deku off to the infirmary for injuries, Bakugou was all but ordering Ochako, Iida or Todoroki to do it.

In the winter, she had noticed that the weather had been affecting Deku's movements, but she didn't know how to broach the subject, but Bakugou just bulldozed through all of Deku's

protests about being fine and had been super blunt with Deku. It was kind of sweet in Bakugou's own way of caring.

She would never admit it, but Bakugou sort did the same for the rest of the class—looked after them too. But everyone agreed that Bakugou liked his mean asshole persona for his reputation as a badass and agreed not to let anyone know how much of a good, soft-hearted guy Bakugou really was. Except, it was really getting harder with all the unguarded looks Bakugou gave Deku when the green-haired teenager wasn't looking.

Ochako was about ninety-five percent certain that Bakugou returned the feelings Deku held, but he hadn't realized it yet. Especially after Deku's last bad injury gave Bakugou that dark, haunted look in his eyes for two days. Now that Deku realized his own crush (finally), she had to make sure no one interrupted their progress. There would be *no meddling* in their relationship.

She firmly believed that if they were going to get their shit together, they had to do it on their own or it wouldn't mean as much when they worked out.

Luckily, she knew that Todoroki, Momo and Kirishima all agreed with her on the subject of no meddling.

"Uraraka, please come up to the board and rewrite the sentence in English please!"

She eeped and hoped that she wasn't getting called on because she was not paying attention.

"Yes!"

_~_~_~_~_~

They had night training that evening, so after dinner Class 2-A and Class 2-B shuffled off to Ground Beta. The teachers explained that it was necessary to have night training because things were a little different at night than during the day and one day, some of them will have the night or overnight shifts of hero patrols at their agencies. It was also decided that the two classes would be teamed up in various group for the assignments.

Ochako found herself in a group with Bakugou and Monoma. Deku was so lucky that he got to be in the group with Tetsutetsu and Kirishima, the three were all very excitable together. Bakugou bumped her shoulder when he came to stand next to her.

"Don't worry, Round Face, just because we got dead weight, we'll still win," said Bakugou, smirking at her, the heated comment towards Monoma of Class 2-B. Bakugou and Monoma were not two people that should ever speak. Monoma grated on her nerves even and she could only imagine how much the strange copy-quirk boy, who made an enemy of Bakugou at their first Sports Festival.

She didn't even scold him for being rude. Monoma wasn't that much of dead weight, but he talked way too much.

“I can’t believe I have to work with you arrogant Class 2-A punks,” laughed Monoma. “You’re the ones that will be dead weight.”

Ochako and Bakugou ignored him. “So, what’s the plan for the evacuation, Bakugou?”

“I ain’t Deku and his plans, but figured that with your quirk and this shit-stain’s copy quirk you can float the heavy stuff and I’ll grab the victims,” said Bakugou, simply. Their exercise was to sort through rubble at a collapsed building and fish out survivors (i.e. the dummies hidden by the teachers for the task). “Hey, shit-stain, copy her quirk when we get sent in and follow her lead.”

“I don’t have to listen to you,” said Monoma, grumbling.

“You will so we win,” said Bakugou, scowling. Ochako sighed. This was going to be a long assignment if Monoma wasn’t going to cooperate. “Heroes have to work together, even if we don’t like each other. Get with the fucking program or I’ll kill you.”

“God, how does your weird, nerdy boyfriend deal with you, you brute?”

“HAH?”

Ochako’s eyes widened. Monoma did not just *freaking say that.* That was the kind of thing that Bakugou definitely didn’t need to hear.

“Who’s my fucking boyfriend? Talking out of your ass again, shit-stain,” growled Bakugou, furious and blushing. Ochako grabbed his arm aimed for setting off an explosion while she wanted to smack Monoma into the stratosphere, they really didn’t need to get in trouble for fighting and she didn’t want to fail the assignment. Bakugou’s arm went to rest at the reminder of Ochako being there and she just held it for good measure.

Monoma titled his head and smirked, like he heard a good joke. “Oh, so Deku’s not your boyfriend? My bad, I mean you follow him like a lost junkyard dog with heart eyes. It’s pathetic.”

“Shut the *fuck* up.”

Ochako surprised herself, and Bakugou and Monoma, because she was the one that said it and not Bakugou. Bakugou looked stunned into silence at the vicious protective stance Ochako took. Monoma looked quite frightened at the glare leveled at him.

“You *do not* get to minimalize the bond between Bakugou and Deku,” stated Ochako, inner fury reaching out in her tone of voice. “Stop being a *shit-stain,* we have work to do and if you can’t get over your stupid imagined rivalry with us to be a hero, then maybe you’re the one with the problem.” Monoma was stunned to silence.

“Damn, Urakara, you destroyed him,” was all Bakugou could get out.

(By the way, they barely passed the assignment as Monoma refused to participate. Ochako and Bakugou were not very happy).

_~_~_~_~_~

“Uraraka-chan, what are we going to do,” Kirishima asked. “They haven’t talked to each other in two days. I’m really getting worried.”

Ochako, Iida, Todoroki, Kaminari, Shinsou, Sero, Kirishima and Mina were in the library for a study session that was supposed to include Bakugou and Deku. Deku went to his room before dinner and it was only Tokoyami’s Dark Shadow flying in him dinner to let everyone know that Deku ate. Bakugou stomped around the common room, in a foul-mood, as he did the dinner dishes and then stormed off to his room.

Iida was busy explaining some math problems to Sero and Mina, while Shinsou was helping Mina with her essay. Todoroki was working on his own essay.

Kirishima and Ochako had to write an English dialogue together for their English class. Ochako sighed. “Me too. I mean, any time their eyes meet, Deku becomes a blushing mess and Bakugou just gets angry. Damnit, they were doing so well too.”

Kirishima patted Ochako on the head. “I know we said that we shouldn’t meddle, but I think they’re floundering a bit about what to do.”

“Do you think that Bakugou realized his feelings,” asked Ochako.

Kirishima shrugged helplessly. “I mean, Monoma basically spelled it out for him from what you told me, but he might still be in denial, being stubborn as he is.”

“Well, I can talk to Deku and you can talk to Bakugou. They just need someone to listen without judgement,” said Ochako.

“Or, we could just lock them in a room together until they talk,” commented Todoroki, the slight inflection in his tone told her it was a joke.

“That would be like cornering them and might make it worse,” said Kirishima, who didn’t get that Todoroki was joking. Ochako smiled.

“Todoroki-kun is joking,” said Ochako, patting Kirishima’s head. “Let’s finish this assignment and I’ll go talk to Deku.”

“And I’ll talk to Bakugou.”

_~_~_~_~_~

“Deku, please open up. I wanna talk to you,” said Ochako, knocking on Deku’s dorm room door, loudly. “Please, Deku, I’m worried about you.”

The door opened and Ochako’s heart melted at the sight of a dazed Deku who looked so sad. “Hey, I’m okay, Uraraka-chan.”

Ochako couldn’t help herself and she hugged him. “Oh, Deku, it’s okay not to be okay sometimes. You can always come to me, whenever.”

Deku gently hugged her back. “I don’t know what to do. I’m a mess.”

“Deku, it’s gonna be fine,” said Ochako, soothingly as possible. When she found out that she had a crush on Deku, she panicked too, just like Deku. “I just hate to see you and Bakugou’s hard work to rebuild your friendship go to waste because you’re too embarrassed about your crush on him.”

Deku ripped himself out of the hug and flailed his arms. “You know too?!”

Ochako smiled, softly. “I’m your best friend, of course I figured it out, Deku.” Deku sighed and lead Ochako inside his room, despite being super close to curfew. “So, talk. I know you won’t talk about this stuff with Todoroki or Iida, but you can with me. You don’t have to ashamed of your feelings, Deku, promise.”

In Deku’s All Might shrine of a room, Ochako sat at the chair of Deku’s desk, while Deku planted himself on his bed. “I just, it’s like so confusing, Uraraka-chan. I mean, it’s like I’m seeing him differently now, but at the same time, he’s still Kacchan. I’m not making any sense.”

“Feelings don’t make sense, Deku. But I think I get it. He’s like blinding right? Like he’s the one thing that you focus on, no matter what. He grabs your attention, whether you like it or not,” said Ochako, knowingly. Too knowingly that Deku shot her a concerned look. Ochako waved him off. “So we’ve established your feelings, so what are you going to do about it?”

Deku opened his mouth, closed it and frowned.

“Deku. Nothing is not an answer to this.”

“What am I supposed to do,” he asked, upset.

Ochako sighed. “What do you want? Don’t overthink it. Do you want to tell Bakugou how you feel and ask him out? Do you want to wait and see if he likes you and tells you first? You have to talk to him. Miscommunication is the reason for all your past problems with him.”

“I don’t know what I want, but I know that I don’t want to lose Kacchan’s friendship,” said Deku, simply. Ochako felt bad that Deku was so confused.

“You won’t lose his friendship,” said Ochako, in a matter-of-fact tone. “Crushes and romance aside, you two both care about each other as friends. That won’t change, not after you two came so far.”

Deku smiled. “I guess you’re right.”

“So, now I have a question for you,” said Ochako. She really hated to do this to him, but she had to see how far his feelings went for Bakugou. “How would you feel if someone else, someone, I don’t know, a good person with a cool quirk and going to be a great hero, hypothetically speaking, asked Bakugou out on a date and Bakugou agreed? What if they kept dating? What if that someone and Bakugou got married? That hypothetical someone would be by Bakugou’s side always.”

Deku made a face, biting his bottom lip. “But that’s my spot.” Then Deku clamped his mouth shut with his hands. Deku looked at her mildly horrified because she posed an undesired what-if situation and that he just revealed a little selfishness to her.

Ochako said, “I figured as much. If there was a mysterious person courting Bakugou, you would fight for him wouldn’t you?” He nodded.

“Oh my God, what’s wrong with me,” said Deku.

“You’re in love, that’s why. Now, what do you want to do, Deku?”

Chapter End Notes

Ochako and Kirishima didn't want to meddle with the progress of Kacchan and Izuku's relationship since it would be better if they came to terms on their own, but the two are good friends and knew when to step in to help.

Also if you like Monoma from Class B, he was the easiest to make the comment that upset Bakugou since canonically, Monoma doesn't care for Bakugou and vice-versa.

Life's a Balancing Act

Chapter Summary

Katsuki deals...

Chapter Notes

Kiribaku BROTP!!!!

LAST CHAPTER, FOLKS, ENJOY!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Unable to concentrate on his homework, Katsuki just sat at his desk playing a game on his phone. The rapid knocking at the door didn't help. Katsuki scowled when Kirishima knocked yet again on his dorm room door. "Go away, Shitty Hair!" This has been going on for ten minutes now.

Though muffled by the door, Kirishima's voice was clear. "Open the door, Bakugou. I'm worried about you and you need someone to talk to!"

He didn't want to talk that much was certain. Katsuki didn't want to talk to Kirishima or anyone at the moment. He didn't want to talk about the strange feeling in his chest when that shit-stain from Class 2-B called Deku his boyfriend. Clearly, Deku's been acting weird since then. Deku and Uraraka talked often, as much as Katsuki and Kirishima, so she might have brought it up and now Deku couldn't even look him in the eyes.

Sure, he was acting weird before then when he tripped on their morning run two days ago, but Katsuki chalked it up to Deku just being his normal anxious self.

"Come on, bro," Kirishima tried again. "I just don't want you to push yourself away from Mido. You guys are friends!"

Katsuki got out of his chair and went to the door and slammed it open. "Fine, come in, but nothing you hear leaves this room or I'll make your life hell, Shitty Hair!" Katsuki almost wanted to punch Kirishima, who seemed very pleased with himself for getting into Katsuki's room to talk about feelings of all things.

These unnamed, but known feelings were inconvenient for Katsuki.

And now Kirishima was giving him a soft, friendly look that made Katsuki want to punch his face again, but Katsuki resisted out of his genuine friendship with the red-head.

“So, what the fuck do you want to talk about?”

“Easy, man,” said Kirishima. “Listen if you’ve been avoiding Mido because of what Monoma said, then don’t. Alright, Monoma doesn’t get it and it’s not his business.”

Katsuki growled. “It’s not fucking me! I couldn’t care less what that dip-shit thinks about me! It’s fucking Deku. It’s always fucking Deku, Kirishima! He’s awkward around me because he thinks that I got a crush or some shit on him. Not only is it freaking him out, but it’ll ruin things with Round Face for him. I won’t do that to either of them.”

Kirishima made a confused face. “Bro, you’re giving me some contradictory stuff here. I’m not reading this whole thing wrong, am I?”

Katsuki clamped his mouth shut, scowling deeply. He crossed his arms and refused to look at his best friend, who just wanted to help.

“Oh, bro, I know it’s not a crush. It’s okay to be in love with him,” said Kirishima, in the most sympathetic tone ever. Kirishima moved to put a hand on Katsuki’s shoulder in a comforting manner. “It’s okay to say that you’re in love with Midoriya. I won’t tell anyone.”

“It doesn’t matter, Kirishima,” said Katsuki, snapping. “You don’t fucking *get* it. Deku won’t ever feel that way about me! It’s not like I deserve him…”

Kirishima frowned at him and gave him a dirty look. “Don’t put yourself down like that, Bakugou. Midoriya would be so mad at you for thinking that shit. You’ve grown up a lot, we all have. And you told me yourself that you apologized to Mido for your past ways, right? And Mido forgave you. You mean so much to each other. I just don’t you two to go back to the way you were before. Bakugou and Midoriya, Deku and Kacchan, are a Wonder Duo.” Katsuki snorted at the cheesiest, but warm truth that Kirishima was spouting.

Smiling Kirishima continued, “And for your information Midoriya doesn’t have a crush on Uraraka-chan.”

“The fuck? How do you know?” Katsuki didn’t like the idea of Deku telling super important things to someone else first.

“Relax. I know because he just looks at her like a friend, the same way he looks at the other girls,” said Kirishima. “He doesn’t look at her the way the others do to their crushes. Do you know the looks that Todoroki gives Momo when she’s not looking? Or the looks that Kaminari gives Jirou…?”

“Or the looks that you give Pinky. Alright I get it. So Deku doesn’t have a thing for Uraraka, but she still has feelings for Deku. She’s my friend too. And if Deku was to go off and be with someone, Uraraka would be the only one I would accept at all,” said Katsuki, making a face. “You had better not ever tell her that. I’ll deny it.”

Kirishima laughed. “So you admit that you love Midoriya?”

“Shit, you suck. Of course I love the shitty nerd, what part about it *always* being fucking Deku didn’t you get, Shitty Hair!?”

Laughing still, Kirishima said, “I have a message for you from Uraraka-chan. She told me to tell you that if you don’t say something, she really will attempt to steal Mido from you.”

“She can fucking try,” growled Katsuki. And then he realized what he just said.

Quickly getting a big bear hug from Kirishima, Katsuki’s best friend said, “I knew you wanted to fight for him and not just be all noble and give him up.”

“…you’re lucky I don’t punch you in the face.”

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“Good morning, Kacchan,” chirped Deku as soon as Katsuki stepped into the kitchen to make the class breakfast. He slept a little later than he normally did, but he did have a stressful feeling conversation with Kirishima that weighed on his mind. So the chipper, cheeriness of Deku after two days of the green haired boy ignoring Katsuki surprised him.

Katsuki narrowed his eyes and grunted out a “Morning.”

Katsuki settled in a spot standing next to Deku who was making the batter for pancakes. They worked in relative silence, uncomfortable for Katsuki and not for Deku, making the pancakes and other morning foods.

“Kacchan,” said Deku. Katsuki’s head involuntarily turned to the sound of Deku saying his name and Katsuki wound up staring into Deku’s green eyes. “I’m sorry I was being weird for the last couple of days. It was just something new that came up and I panicked for a bit, but I figured things out.”

“Ah,” said Katsuki, unsure whether or not Deku knew about Katsuki’s feelings or not. But Deku was starting the conversation between them again and Katsuki was grateful. “Tell me when you’re ready. Or if you need to talk. Or whatever.”

Deku grinned, eyes sparkling. “Hmm, thanks Kacchan. You’re the best. I don’t know what I would do without you.”

“Hah? Of course I am,” said Katsuki, in an instinctive response. “And you’d be half-assing shit if I wasn’t around. Now get with the program. We’ve got breakfast to finish, nerd.”

And just like that things between them eased back to normal before that strange morning when Deku tripped over his two feet.

But then, the change went too much in the other direction as after breakfast, Katsuki found himself being handed a bento box lunch by Deku before he joined Uraraka, Todoroki and Iida to walk to class together with them. Kirishima and Kaminari bum-rushed Katsuki and slung their arms over his shoulders, so he had one on each side of them.

“What the fuck…?”

“Hmm, what’s this,” asked Kaminari. “Deku made you lunch? That’s so thoughtful of him.”

“He’s a good guy, isn’t he,” stated Kirishima. Katsuki shot his best friend a murderous look because he knew something was up, but Katsuki had no idea what the hell was going and it was really pissing him off. Kirishima knew something. He found it very odd that the night after they talked about Katsuki’s feelings that Deku talked to him again.

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Katsuki felt his face was on fire the entire day and he felt that everyone was staring at him being absolutely embarrassing. First with this morning and then when Katsuki was passing the newest assignments back, Deku’s scarred hand touched Katsuki’s for more than appropriate when doing the task. AND then, during morning training, Deku decided that it was a leg day for him and did squats with Iida. (Perhaps, that was just Katsuki’s own fault for being distracted).

He finally made it to lunch without setting off his quirk in anyone’s face (points for him for not using violence). Against his better judgement, what was wrong with him today, he sat with his normal group of friends. Only when they stared at him expectantly, he realized that he had the lunch that Deku made for him and while Katsuki liked Lunch Rush’s food, it would be rude not to eat what Deku made him.

He opened it and found halfway decent looking food (Deku wasn’t as incompetent in the kitchen as the others), but a little cheery note on a piece of paper. “Thanks for everything, Kacchan. You’re amazing. ^_^”

Despite the rice being overcooked and the meat being a bit dry, Deku did put in enough spices from Katsuki’s section of the spice cabinet in the dorm kitchen that the overwhelming heat overpowered the bad parts of the lunch. He ate everything.

“You and me are teaming up for spars this afternoon, Shitty Hair,” Katsuki told Kirishima after Katsuki finished the bento without a complaint. Kirishima was put on notice because Katsuki still knew something was up and his best friend knew what was up and didn’t tell Katsuki. Kirishima just grinned grimly.

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Of course, nothing was ever that easy and Katsuki got paired up to spar with Todoroki in the afternoon lessons. Normally, as both were easily two of the four strongest in the class, they didn’t get regular sparring sessions. Katsuki always liked when the teachers let him have a go at Todoroki, Yaoyorozu or Deku.

“Good luck, Kacchan, even though you don’t need it because you’re so powerful,” called out Deku from where he stood against his opponent in the form of Kaminari. “No offense, Todoroki-kun!”

Katsuki felt his face heat up again and he had no idea why. Katsuki only nodded, while Todoroki didn't take offense.

"I thought I was awkward," commented Todoroki, giving Katsuki that annoying little smirk.

"You are, Icy-Hot," shot Katsuki back. "Let just fight alright?" Todoroki just shrugged nonchalantly in a manner that Katsuki knew that Todoroki knew annoyed him to no end. "Take this seriously, you fucker!"

"Bakugou, language," called out Iida from nearby.

"Yes, Young Bakugou, language," commented All Might, monitoring this particular class with Aizawa-sensei that day.

Bakugou just scowled and got ready to fight.

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Night training resumed again that night after dinner. This time, they were paired up in the mostly normal pairs, which meant that Katsuki was with Deku that evening. Katsuki had really wanted to talk to Deku about the strangeness before the night training—the excessive compliments, the lunch and the dessert that Deku prepared for the class (cheesecakes, did Deku not sleep the night before?) Katsuki had to find out why Deku was doing this and why this was really throwing Katsuki for a loop. But training started almost immediately with no reprieve to talk.

And naturally once they were on the field, they were professionals who had a job to do and Katsuki no longer complained about working together with Deku. Their synchronized fighting was actually getting far better than Katsuki or Deku had ever hoped. He knew there were a few moves that Deku wanted to try together when they got permission from the teachers in Deku's notebook.

As Deku smashed the last bot to bits (poor support department), Katsuki evacuated the "victim" (Aizawa-sensei this time).

"Not bad this time, problem children," commented Aizawa-sensei, walking away to get to his next post as a victim.

"Thanks, sensei," said Deku, cheerfully, as Deku rushed up to be at Katsuki's side. "Kacchan, we did really well. We're a good team, aren't we?"

Katsuki smirked. "We're the best, nerd, remember that."

Deku laughed. "Of course, I couldn't lose, not with you at my side. You're the best."

Blushing, Katsuki stuttered out a "Shut up." Were they flirting? Katsuki was pretty sure they were flirting with each other and he didn't know what to do from there.

Grinning Deku replied, "I'm gonna compliment you until you get used to it Kacchan."

Poor Katsuki's heart at the side of a positively blinding, smiling Deku.

Good God, he, Bakugou Katsuki, really did love Midoriya Izuku so much that he didn't know what to do.

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When he was supposed to be sleeping, Katsuki was pacing and setting off little explosions in his hands out of frustration in his room. He really needed to talk to Deku and clear everything up between them otherwise it would drive Katsuki crazy. There was only so much of Deku being extra nice to him that Katsuki could take before it exploded his heart.

The walls of the dorms were thin and he knew that Kirishima was in his room next door trying to sleep (it was 2am), so it wasn't a surprised that he heard Kirishima yell "DUDE, I'M EXHAUSTED, PLEASE JUST GO AND CONFESS ALREADY!"

"SCREAM IT TO THE FUCKING WORLD WHY DON'T YOU, SHITTY HAIR, FOR FUCK'S SAKE!!!"

"WOULD YOU TWO STOP SCREAMING I'M TRYING TO SLEEP," complained Tokoyami, who gotten upset being soundly beaten by Asui in the training so he was trying to get some sleep.

"YEAH BAKUGOU GO CONFESS YOUR UNDYING LOVE TO MIDORIYA," teased Dark Shadow, who never slept at night.

"OH MY GOD, SHUT THE FUCK UP!"

Katsuki stormed out of his room and stalked to the door that lead to the stairs to walk to the second floor where Deku's room was located. If he went to the elevator there was no telling how antsy he would have been to stand still.

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At Deku's door, it was eerily similar to the night of Katsuki's apology after Deku almost got himself killed. For a moment, he stood there wondering if this was a mistake and if he should just go back upstairs to his room and forget anything. But he was Bakugou Katsuki and he was not a person to back down to a challenge. So he knocked.

Deku was a night owl, so it was hit or miss if he would be awake or not.

The door opened to reveal and sleepy Deku in his sweats and t-shirt, rubbing his eyes. "Kacchan? Is everything okay?" Deku yawned, cutely.

Katsuki's heart was about to combust at the adorableness of Deku.

"I, uh, just, you know what you were sleeping, never mind," said Katsuki, quickly. He attempted to turn around but Deku caught his arms.

"Kacchan, what's wrong?"

Stupidly, Katsuki turned back around and saw the determined look on Deku's face, the same face that told him that Deku wanted to help Katsuki. Deku was always there for Katsuki, in all the bad times and the good times and everything in between. Deku followed him and now Katsuki was following *him* in their path to become heroes.

"Kacchan?"

"I just want to tell you," said Katsuki, breathing in deep, "that I thought you should know that I love you. I love you and I want you to be by my side in every way….So, now that you know. Good night, Izuku." Katsuki bolted down the hall, not willing to hear the response, and up the stairs.

He should have figured that Deku wasn't going to be happy with Katsuki leaving after confessing his love. He heard the tell-tale cackle of Deku's green lightning as Katsuki upped his speed to get away. He got to the stairwell and ran.

"KACCHAN, GET BACK HERE! WE HAVE TO TALK!"

Deku caught up and crashed into Katsuki somewhere between the second and third floor. Tackled to the ground and being held down by an annoyed Deku in a very uncomfortable spot on the stairs. Deku's intense green eyes bored into Katsuki's soul.

Then there were the tears.

"Kacchan's so mean. Running away after telling me the nicest thing in the world," said Deku, sniffling. "I love you too and I want you by my side in every way too, Kacchan!"

"Well, you did chase me down, so I guess I have to believe you."

"Oh, Kacchan, I'll tell you every day."

"Please, don't, I can't take you flirting with me in public, Deku, alright?" Katsuki and Deku smiled at each other, broadly.

Should they kiss now? Katsuki thought they should, but before either moved they were tied up and facing a very peeved Aizawa-sensei.

"Now, problem children, what do you think you're doing now?"

(The week of detention was definitely worth the kiss Katsuki got the next morning in the kitchen).

Chapter End Notes

Thanks to everyone who commented, gave kudos, subscribed or even just read it and enjoyed it.

Uraraka and the girls helped Deku flirt in his own way with Kacchan.

I hope that you liked the ending.

SPECIAL EXTRA CHAPTER: Date Night

Chapter Summary

SPECIAL EXTRA CHAPTER
Katsuki attempts to be romantic and it backfires horrendously.

Chapter Notes

Hey all! Happy new year and all that stuff! I finished this story back in October, but I came up with an extra chapter to thank everyone for their nice comments and kudos and bookmarks. You all made this my most popular story.

So enjoy!

"Baku, you're as romantic as a doornail," exclaimed Mina, bursting into Katsuki's room, uninvited and unwanted. Katsuki was attempting to study at his desk since they had several big exams upcoming, but of course, his friends were always bothering him. It was bad enough that the dorms had just gotten louder into their 2nd year. Katsuki just wanted some peace and quiet, preferably watching movies and cuddled with his boyfriend on the couch, but they were heroes-in-training and such novelties were few and far between.

Katsuki scowled. "What are you talking about now, Pinky?"

Mina made herself home on his bed and grinned at him. "I'm talking about you and Mido! You've been dating six months this Saturday you know?"

"I find really intrusive and creepy that there's 19 people keeping track of me and Deku's relationship milestones," snarked Katsuki, throwing a pen at Mina's head. "It was bad enough that everyone in the class ***followed us on our first date!*** Get out of my room and leave me be!"

Mina giggled. "So, do you have any plans to impress Deku on your six-month-a-versary?"

Katsuki sighed and rubbed his temples. "Pinky, it's not your goddamn business, but we're trading gifts." Katsuki and Izuku both were only very reluctantly trading gifts for the occasion, only after well-placed comments from Shinsou and Kaminari got them thinking about the milestones of their relationship.

Frowning, Mina titled her head. "That's it?"

Katsuki scowled. “Yes, that’s *fucking* it. Can you leave me be now?”

“You’re telling me that Mido, the light of our class, is only worth a measly exchange of gifts. Doesn’t he deserved to be wined and dined and wooed by his loving boyfriend,” replied Mina. “Weak.”

Katsuki had enough of her sass and stood up. He marched over and picked her up, throwing the petite pink girl over his shoulder. She shrieked, but not in terror, no this girl was not one to be afraid of Bakugou Katsuki. She was having fun while Katsuki manhandled her. He carried her to the door of his room, which she left wide open when she burst in.

Then, he tossed her into the hallway, not gentle, but not so nice. He quickly slammed the door to his room shut and locked it to keep intruders out. No one had any sense of personal space anymore.

Katsuki grunted and went back to his desk chair to continue his homework.

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“Do you think she’s right, Hair-for-Brains,” asked Katsuki, as they lunged the dorms’ collective trash to the dumpsters as it was their turn on the chore chart set up by Momo. While Kirishima did get wrapped up in the class’s shenanigans, Kirishima was the only one that Katsuki would even consider talking to about Katsuki’s relationship with Izuku. It was Kirishima that gave Katsuki advice all those months ago, after all. The red head was Katsuki’s best friend, other than Deku.

“I mean, I think she just likes messing with you,” said Kirishima, sighing about his oldest friend’s antics. “And I think that she doesn’t realize that every couple’s relationships are different. Izuku’s not about grand gestures, nor are you. It’s the quiet, little things that matter the most. Maybe most especially for you two.”

Katsuki knew what Kirishima was saying was the truth. Other than their first date, Katsuki and Izuku managed to carve out quiet dinners, movie nights, and training together as the chaos of their second year at U.A. didn’t allow for much free time. But Mina’s words got under his skin more that Katsuki liked to admit. After everything that he and Izuku went through (admittedly mostly because of him, but Izuku too), shouldn’t Katsuki be making more of an effort to impress Izuku, to show Izuku how much Katsuki really did love him? Katsuki didn’t mind the quiet evenings, but maybe Izuku wanted a bit more effort and Izuku was just being himself and not wanting to be a bother.

“Bro, don’t overthink it. I know you’re still fighting your insecurities, just as much as Izuku is fighting his,” said Kirishima. “But if you do want to plan an epic anniversary date? I’ll help.”

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“We’re going somewhere,” asked Izuku, slightly confused as Katsuki told him that they were going to go out on Saturday evening. With Kirishima’s help (and only his help, like he would

ask the rest of the nut-jobs in his class for help, over his dead body), Katsuki planned a fantastic date. Now, he just had to get Izuku on board for a trip on Saturday.

“Yeah, I got permission from Aizawa-sensei already,” said Katsuki. It was hard to get permission to go out of the school grounds unless it was for internship work or visiting parents. Aizawa was just surprised enough that Katsuki was even asking that he agreed, so long as Katsuki and Izuku were home a half-hour before lights out. “You need a break, nerd.”

Izuku grinned at him. “Always looking out for me, Kacchan. Alright, a break does sound nice. How should I dress?”

Katsuki smirked. “Make a bit of effort, Deku. No shirts that say ‘t-shirt’ on it, at least.” He said it fondly as he ruffled Deku’s already messy hair.

His boyfriend batted Katsuki’s hand away playfully. Still grinning, “I’ll have you know that’s the height of my fashion sense.”

“Don’t I know it,” said Katsuki, fondly, leaning over and kissing Izuku’s forehead. “Don’t be late. Meet me at 5 in the common room.”

“Sounds good.”

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“Wow, look at you,” said Ochako. She, Tsuyu, Iida and Todoroki were the only ones in the common room of the dorms. About half the class had internships to attend that evening and the rest were either training or studying. “You know, if it weren’t for your personality, I would definitely think you’re a catch.”

Katsuki scowled. He flipped the middle finger at them. He didn’t curse her out though, mostly because she was merely teasing him and didn’t mean it and mostly because he still felt a little guilty that he was constantly shoving his happiness with Izuku in her face (despite the claim that she was definitely over Izuku now).

Still, he wanted to remain as calm as possible. He did make an effort in his appearance tonight. He wore his nicest black Jordan’s, a pair of black jeans with a belt with a dragon buckle that was a gift from Izuku for Katsuki’s 17th birthday, and to top it off he wore a forest green button up shirt. He had his handmade jacket (from his parents) with a big orange X on the back for his hero symbol as Ground Zero.

“Classy,” quipped Todoroki, not even looking up from his textbook.

“Bakugou-chan does look very good tonight though, ribbit,” said Tsuyu, giving Katsuki a thumps up in encouragement. “Midoriya-chan will be pleased.”

As if being summoned, Izuku came down the stairs, actually ready. Katsuki had to count backwards from 20 to not have his brain short-circuit. Izuku actually made an effort. Still wearing his classic red Jordan’s, he wore a nice pair of slacks that fit him quite nicely. He wore a plain white t-shirt and over it was a green and black flannel long sleeve shirt. He

carried his favorite All Might pullover. “I’m not late!” Izuku rushed over to Katsuki, and took his arm. “I almost didn’t make it.”

Fighting a blush that threatened to overtake his face, Katsuki said, “You, uh, look good, nerd.”

Izuku beamed. “You always look good, Kacchan.”

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Things were not going well right off the bat. At first it was. They took a cab to the restaurant where he made reservations. The restaurant was one of those middling-expensive ones that apparently had the best desserts. Knowing that Izuku had a sweet tooth, Katsuki thought his boyfriend would like it.

But then when they got out of the car and Katsuki was momentarily distracted paying the driver, he heard some screeching. He turned to find Izuku already sprinting after a purse thief, who had a dozen or so purses. Katsuki naturally chase after Izuku, despite knowing that Izuku could handle the situation. They both had their provisional hero licenses, so even when they weren’t at their internships, they still had to act if they saw something.

Half-hour later, after capturing the villain, talking to the cops, and returning all the purses to the victims of the theft, they had missed their reservation. Katsuki cursed up a storm about it, but Izuku didn’t mind.

Izuku just grinned at him. “Don’t worry about it. There’s a great ramen place near here, we can eat there.”

Reluctantly, Katsuki followed Izuku to a hole-in-a-wall ramen shop, because of course Izuku found small, cozy place for them to go. Admittedly as they ordered, he enjoyed eating at the counter listening to Izuku talk about the criminal’s quirk. The food was better there anyway.

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“We’re going to an art gallery,” questioned Izuku as they waited at the bus stop. They needed to take the bus to get to the art gallery in the next part of their date.

“It’s some artist whose focus is on heroes,” said Katsuki, shrugging nonchalantly. He had to act like it was no big deal, especially since he found the artist online and even spoke to Tokoyami, who was a fan, about it. It was just up Izuku’s alley of hero fanboying.

Izuku’s lit up with interest. “Really? That does sound fun. I didn’t even know about it.” They continue their conversation, speculating which heroes the artist might have use as inspiration. Katsuki really liked that it was getting easier and easier for him to talk to Izuku like they hadn’t been at odds more than a year and a half ago. Ten minutes later, the bus pulled up and the two heroes-in-training climbed aboard to their next date destination.

The bus was crowded as it was Saturday and a lot people went out on Saturdays, so they had to stand and hold onto the handrails. Katsuki really like that he got to keep Izuku close to

him.

They didn't even get to the next stop when the bus stopped working. Katsuki growled slightly in annoyance. It was just his luck that the moment he tried to be romantic and outgoing, things went to shit.

Everyone had to leave the bus while the bus driver called his headquarters. Moments later, they were informed that a replacement bus would be there in a half-hour or they could take the subway to their destinations.

Katsuki must have been making some sort of disgruntled face because Izuku grabbed his hand and began leading him away from the crowd. "We can't wait otherwise we won't make it back in time for half-hour before lights-out. We'll go to the art gallery another time. There's a nice park over there, Kacchan. Let's just go for a walk. I'm still a little full from the ramen, anyway."

Maybe a peaceful walk in the park was just what Katsuki needed to get his feelings of insecurity and inadequacy under control.

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It started raining. Because of course, it started raining. Katsuki was 95% sure that there had been no rain the weather forecast because he double-checked the weather report at least 17 times before their date. Luckily, they spotted a gazebo and they rushed for the cover it. It wasn't super dry but at least they were not getting soaked.

"Ah, once the rain lets up, we should head back to the dorms," said Izuku, eyes watching the sky.

Katsuki did not respond. He knew that a stupid planned date would not work out. Katsuki was not good at the mushy, cheesy stuff. He was madder at himself. Mina really got under his skin, more than he thought.

"Kacchan? Are you okay?"

The concern in Izuku's pretty green eyes made Katsuki's heart lurch. There was no way that he was remotely good enough for the young man standing before Katsuki. "Fine."

Izuku wrinkled his nose and frowned. "Don't do that."

"Do what?"

"Cut me out when the talk becomes about feelings and stuff. We promised that we would both try harder right?"

Katsuki was not one to break promises, so naturally Izuku would bring it up. "It's really nothing."

"Kacchan," said Izuku, sighing. "Is it about the date you planned not going the way you wanted it? I don't care about that Kacchan. I just want to spend time with you, any time I can

get. We're only gonna get busier from here when we reach third year…"

"You deserve nice dates and nice things, Izuku," said Katsuki, snapping.

Izuku looked baffled. "We *do* have nice dates. I like when you cook dinner especially for me. And I like watching movies and documentaries with you. And I know that Uraraka-chan says that training is not dates, but I think they are."

"I'm not talking about those. Pinky said that I should and I quote "wine and dine you", you know romantic gestures and whatever," said Katsuki, scowling that Izuku was so damn content at the moment.

Izuku smiled softly and pulled out of the pocket of his hoodie a neatly wrapped package. He put it in Katsuki's hands. "Since when do you listen to other people, Kacchan? I don't need grand gestures. Every day with you is an adventure, a gift. Every day you show me how much you love me and there's nothing better than that, Kacchan."

"You're such a sap," said Katsuki, so very fond of his childhood friend, his rival and his boyfriend. From his own coat pocket, he pulled out the gift for Izuku.

"Mhm, you love me anyway," said Izuku.

Together they opened the gifts—Katsuki was gifted with a fire-resistant earbuds. He did need new ones after a rough game of Mario Kart against Kaminari, Sero, Mina and Kirishima.

Izuku gasped at his. "Kacchan, is this…"

Katsuki felt his face turn red.

In Izuku's hands was a glass-encased piece of the wall from the hallway of Katsuki's parents' house. When they were barely four, the two scribbled on the hallway wall their names (Kacchan and Izuku) with crude drawings of them as heroes. His parents had both been annoyed and amused. They simply had the hallway wallpapered, but Katsuki thought they painted over the picture.

Two weeks ago, he got a call from his dad—Katsuki's parents were extending their workroom and during construction, his dad saved the drawing on the wall and wanted Katsuki to have it.

"This is so wonderful, Kacchan. I'll treasure it forever," said Izuku, holding it to his chest like an All Might trading card.

"Yeah well…"

"I love you so much," said Izuku, leaning over and kissing him gently on the lips.

Katsuki felt himself smiling. "Love you too."

It wasn't such a bad anniversary date, after all.

End Notes

So, my hands hurt badly in the late autumn and winter, as I am older than you probably think I am (between typing, writing, and work, my hands take some abuse), so when I saw what Izuku did to his hands repeatedly and just knew that when the colder weather hit, Izuku's hands were going to be in pain, even though he's so young. And Izuku being Izuku will not want to bother anyone...

The cold hit me suddenly this year and I was inspired to write this...

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!